

STRANDS OF A VISION

VINOBA

Edited and Translated By
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PARAMDHAM PRAKASHAN, PAVNAR

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Preface

Acharya Vinoba Bhave (1895-1982) is undoubtedly one of the greatest personalities of the last century. Acclaimed as 'Gandhi's spiritual successor' he was, in fact, a successor to most of the ancient spiritual traditions of the world. Philosophy, metaphysics, sociology, political science, pedagogy, economics—there was hardly any subject that his genius did not touch and in which he did not contribute novel, original and insightful ideas. Those ideas assume more importance in the light of the fact that Vinoba was not only a theoretician, but he also practised what he preached, and demonstrated the practicality of what he conceived. The Bhoodan-Yajna, which he initiated and led, gave more than 2.5 million acres of land to the poor agricultural labourers. This has no parallel in the history of the world.

Vinoba's books, most of which are compilations on different subjects culled from his speeches and writings, have been, and are being, published in various Indian languages. However, only a few of them have been published in English. Hence most of his writings have remained inaccessible in English. This is a serious deficiency, when English is the most widely known international language and the perplexed world urgently needs to become aware of Vinoba's experiential wisdom.

This is what prompted me to resolve to prepare a few books in English by editing and translating Vinoba's thoughts on different subjects, which have not been covered in Vinoba's available literature in English, despite being fully aware of my incompetence to do the job, simply because it has not yet been attempted. The attempt is to give a broad outline of some of Vinoba's thoughts with the hope that they would motivate the readers to delve into Vinoba's timeless wisdom.

Publisher's Note

Vinoba's sagacious words are a treasure-house for humankind. They were perhaps ahead of the times wherein they were uttered, but they are certainly relevant now, when the forces of what Gandhiji called 'a satanic civilisation' are seeking to overpower human spirit. These words can reassure humankind about the ultimate triumph of truth and inspire and guide it in the fight against those forces.

However, only a few of Vinoba's works had been translated in English, whose outreach is increasing in the present era. It is gratifying that Dr. Parag Cholkar has now edited and translated Vinoba's thoughts on some subjects, which have hitherto been unavailable in English, and presented them in the form of nine books. We are happy in publishing them in printed form, while Sarva Seva Sangh Prakashan is publishing them as e-books.

We are thankful to Vidarbha Bhoodan-Gramdan Sahayog Samiti (Nagpur) and Bhoodan-yajna Mandal, Vidarbha for their financial assistance for this project.

Vinoba has himself identified four components of his thought and vision: *samyayog*, *sarvodaya*, *samanvaya* and *satyagraha*. These four concepts form the foundation of his philosophy of life; and consequently of his social, economic and political thought.

He has called 'samyayog' a great discovery of the present age. 'Sarvodaya' is the word which Gandhi had used, but Vinoba extended the breadth and depth of the concept and popularised it so much that the Gandhian movement became more known as the 'Sarvodaya movement'. It was Vinoba who was responsible for the conscious, though uncharacteristic, decision of the Gandhians to refuse to identify the movement with a particular individual, who was its seer and pioneer, even when they were shocked and dazed by his assassination.

Vinoba was not just a theoretician; he was not just a saint who was content with devotion to the Lord and delivering moral sermons. Not that he neglected or discounted the necessity for purity and orderliness in individual life. A revolution can be brought about only by those who have revolutionised their lives. Vinoba was pre-eminently a revolutionary who, therefore, tried to bring about revolution in both individual and society. The revolution he envisaged was to be a nonviolent one, which the world had neither witnessed nor even imagined. In spelling out the features of this revolution, Vinoba revolutionized the process of revolution and imparted to it, in the world of veteran thinker Dada Dharmadhikari, 'the charm of a fine art'.

'Organisation is the test of nonviolence'—Gandhi had declared. Organisation and leadership are two key elements in any revolution and, therefore, Vinoba had to wrestle with the question of moulding an organisation and leadership fit for a nonviolent revolution. Much can be learnt from his novel schemes for mobilising funds for a

revolutionary movement.

Philosophy of history is also an important element in the world-view of any philosopher. Vinoba also has a distinct philosophy of history.

Being a litterateur and a polyglot of the highest order, Vinoba's views on literature—which he held to be a major force in human affairs—and languages also need serious consideration.

'Ramanama: ek chintan' (Reflections on the Ramanama) is an original work by Vinoba. It is actually a long review of Gandhi's book on the Ramanama. In the course of this review, Vinoba has dealt with many points and provided many fresh insights. Quotations from Gandhiji are mostly from his book in English.

The present book has been prepared by stringing together these different strands; and is therefore titled 'Strands of a vision'.

I am happy that Sarva Seva Sangh Prakashan has taken initiative for the publication of this book as an e-book, while Paramdham Prakashan is publishing it in printed form. Vidarbha Bhoodan-Gramdan Sahayog Samiti and Bhoodan-yajna Mandal, Vidarbha have provided financial assistance to this project. I am grateful to them. Readers are welcome to point out errors and deficiencies and suggest modifications.

— Parag Cholkar

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1

The Path and the Goal

My path

I am an explorer on a particular path. It has been my mission to explore the potentialities of nonviolence. The only motive behind all the work that I undertook or forsook, or the work that I am doing now is for this very purpose—to carry out experiments with nonviolence.

How can difficulties of every kind in the life of society and in the life of the individual be overcome through nonviolence? To find this out has been the main objective before me. That has been my chief task.

My walking tour (*padayatra*) for years in connection with Bhoodan-yajna was solely for bringing about union of hearts. In fact, that has been the only motive behind whatever I did in my life.

I firmly believe that human being is a thinking being. Change in thinking brings about transformation in life. It does happen that people do not follow what they believe to be right when opposing currents in the society are strong or when desires or passions sweep them off their feet. But once a thought appeals to a man, it is bound to do its work; his life is bound to get transformed by it sooner or later. This is, in fact, a distinguishing mark of a human being. Human progress has been taking place for thousands of years in this fashion.

That is why I go on explaining my viewpoint. My job is to spell out my thoughts. I am convinced that once a seed of thought is sown it will definitely sprout. People ask, "But how long will it take?" My reply is, "It depends on the time you take to grasp it."

I believe in the power of two things: love and thought. I am moving about with this conviction. Herein

lies my strength. What I desire will be achieved when you fully grasp the thoughts. I do not want to impose anything on anybody. You should act upon these thoughts only if you are convinced about their truth.

It will be wrong if I try to impose anything by force. Similarly, it will also be wrong if I try to impose anything claiming possession of superior knowledge. And it will also be wrong to coerce anybody to accept my viewpoint through acts of self-suffering like fasting. One should fast only for self-purification, introspection, to aid meditation or to strengthen one's resolves. I would put it this way: to impose something through coercive force is a sort of *tamasik* wrong, to impose something through the force of self-suffering is a *rajasik* wrong, and to impose something through the force of knowledge is a *sattvik*¹ wrong. All are forms of coercion. To explain our viewpoint lovingly is the only right and righteous thing for us to do.

I believe that a flame is burning within everybody. It never becomes dim. But when it is covered by something, the light gets obstructed. Once that cover is removed, light will spread instantaneously. How could that cover be removed? Through an understanding of thoughts. That is the way.

In homoeopathic medicines, the quantity of the drug is very small; that of sugar is much more. The doctor keeps on grinding them together. It is said that grinding and succussion enhance potency of the medicine. The thoughts that have been meditated over and over again become more appealing and effective. I hold that thoughts

1. According to the Sankhya philosophy, *prakriti*, or the nature, is constituted of three *gunas*, or essential qualities: *sattva* is the principle of equilibrium and harmony; *rajas* is the principle of passion, restlessness, endeavour and initiation; and *tamas* is the principle of ignorance and inertia.

should be imbued with love. Love is like sugar. If people find a thought hard to digest, one should reduce the quantity of the drug and increase the quantity of love to make it easier to digest.

It should suffice for us to meditate over pure thoughts, understand them, act upon them and explain them to others. To meditate over pure thoughts and express them in words is itself a significant act. The thought should lead to corresponding action in our own lives. Then the only duty we have towards others is to explain the thought to them. Nothing more. And we should continue to follow the discipline necessary for self-purification. That is all that we should do.

We are not proud of any particular country. We do not insist on the practice of any particular religion. We are not bound by the fetters of any particular creed or caste. Roaming around in the beautiful garden of all the noble thoughts in the world constitutes our study. Our duty is to imbibe them. We aim at a creative synthesis of various special features in them and want to foster universal outlook. This is our ideological quest.

Four components of ideology

My thought and vision has four main components. First is the ultimate aim, which I have called '*samyayoga*'.² Second is the philosophy, wherein I stand for *samanvaya* (bringing together and harmonizing different strands of thought)). Third is the social and political goal, which is '*sarvodaya*'.³

2. Vinoba contrasted '*vaad*' (ism or a rigid ideology) with '*yoga*', which denotes union. He enunciated the concept of *samyayoga* (*yoga* of equality and equanimity) and refuted *samyavaad* (communism). The grand concept has been explained in the following pages.

3. Literally, rise or uplift of all. The doctrine is Gandhi-Vinoba's answer to utilitarianism.

And the method to pursue this goal is satyagraha.⁴

Sarvodaya is the social order, which stands on the foundation of the way of life which satyagraha denotes. To achieve this, we will have to bring together and reconcile different ideas and ideologies by averting opposition between them. Reconciliation ends all arguments and disputes. This will ultimately result in the equanimity of the individual and the social mind. I have called this '*samyayoga*'.

'*Samyayoga*' is a word from the Gita, '*samanvaya*' is a word from Vedanta (Upanishadic philosophy) and the word '*sarvodaya*' is a modern one, received from the West.⁵

India, even when she was in bondage, gave three great ideas to the world: (1) Ramakrishna Paramhansa propounded that the world would be saved by the confluence of all the religions. (2) Sri Aurobindo gave the idea that the world would be saved only when we rise to the supramental level. (3) Gandhiji held that the world would be saved when the power of nonviolence becomes manifest through satyagraha. I humbly submit that a fourth idea is making its appearance—*samyayoga*, which is a new discovery in the present age.

Samyayoga

'*Samyayoga*' has three-fold meaning. It is (1) the yoga to be attained through the means of *samya*, (2) the yoga to be practised for the attainment of *samya*, and (3) the yoga whose very nature is *samya*.

4. For a detailed elaboration, see Vinoba's '*Satyagraha*' (English) (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh Prakashan, 2018)

5. In fact, it is an ancient word, and Vinoba has duly acknowledged it. However, it came into prominence following Gandhi's use, and Gandhi used it to denote Ruskin's idea. It is in this sense that it has been called a modern word.

Need for equality

A farmer knows that the field should be plain, not uneven. If there are mounds, water will flow down and will be of no use to the crops; and if there are pits, water will accumulate and stagnate there and crops will rot. He, therefore, breaks mounds and fills pits to have a good crop. This is necessary in the society also.

Acquisitions give rise to laziness and impel one to rob others. This creates a dangerous vicious circle. Security and peace are assured only when equality is there. Human mind is also peaceful when there are no extreme sensations in it.

Today, society is afflicted by differences of all kinds. Caste differences weaken the society, as they hinder the formation of community. In fact, there cannot be a society in the real sense without equality. Problems faced by the world cannot be solved without it.

Quest for equality

Certainly, inequality is presently rampant not only in India but also in the whole world. Yet, it is the age of equality. Every age has a particular prominent demand and accordingly, a particular aspiration becomes widespread. Freedom is valued the most in some age, conscience in another, service in yet another. Everyone in that age works for that aspiration. In the present age, there is quest for equality. The hunger for equality is so strong today that people are ready to take the path of violence to eliminate inequalities even though they are aware of its faults and dangers. Everyone wants relationships with others on equal footing. There has always been hunger for equality; now science is intensifying this hunger. This is evident in every nook and corner of the world.

These days, I am appealing for land-gifts, so that land

can be given to the landless. Some people consider it unnecessary; they say that it is sufficient to give the landless labourers higher wages; that will satisfy them. But if the labourers remain labourers forever and property-owners remain owners forever, that would not make the society happy. That will not bring about the uplift of all.

Broad vision

This bhoodan is nothing but a wedge. How to wean people away from attachment? The beginning is being made from the surrender of land-ownership. Giving land does not mean obliging somebody. Eventually, we want that the land of the village should belong to the whole village. Thereafter, we will say that people from a thickly populated province may go and settle in a province where land is more in proportion to the people. Likewise, people from a thickly populated country may go and settle in a country where land is more in proportion to the people. There should be no barriers on this mother Earth. Thus, we should become world citizens and obliterate all economic, social and political differences. All the air, all the water, all the sunlight on this Earth and this whole Earth itself belongs to all. This is the broad vision of samyayoga.

There will be no differences between high and low in samyayoga. All will be on an equal footing. We will never submit to anyone nor will make anyone submit to us. It is a sin to be afraid of someone and it is equally a sin to intimidate anyone. In samyayoga, there is no question of repressing someone or being repressed.

Compassion is the root, not the end

There are two processes for the attainment of samyayoga: one is that of compassion and another is that of malice. Malice means pulling down those who are above us on the social ladder to create equality. Compassion means rushing to lift up those who are below

us to create equality. Only the process that is rooted in compassion can realize samyayoga.

When you take out a bucketful of water from a well, there is no pit of the size of bucket in it. Instead the level of water in the well goes down, as water drops rush in to fill the void. But if you take out some grains from a grain heap, a cavity is formed. Only some high-souled grains rush in to fill the void! Water levels itself because of mutual affinity between its drops. Samyayoga needs such a compassionate attitude.

Saint Tulsidas has said that compassion is the root of religion. Yes, but it is not the end of it. When the tree of religion blossoms fully, it will bear the fruit of equality. There cannot be a religion without equality. I, therefore, ask those who give land to take the vow to serve the poor. Land-gift is just the first step. When you yourself become poor voluntarily in the course of serving the poor, equality will be established. Poverty will end when it is distributed. Then everyone will be on the same level. In the eyes of sarvodaya, both poverty and prosperity are evil.

While conversing with a British sister, I said that India was facing many problems on account of poverty, but it was not that only poverty gives rise to problems; prosperity could also give rise to many problems. She readily agreed and added that the problems arising in America out of prosperity were perhaps more serious. This is true.

Balance and equilibrium needed

Some people believe that happiness would increase with rise in the standard of living. But this is not the case. A person is happy when he is in a position midway between poverty and prosperity. Extreme poverty causes many sins, and the same is true about extreme prosperity. When extremes of pleasure and pain are avoided, one gets

peace and contentment. There is danger in both, pleasure and pain. If the road is flat, bullocks can happily pull the cart on it and the driver does not have to bother about anything; he may even go to sleep. But if there is considerable slope, the bullocks are likely to start running and may land the cart in a pothole. Likewise, if there is ascent, the bullocks may refuse to move. The same is the case with human beings. Pleasure is akin to slope and pain to ascent. In pleasure, the sense organs long for more of it and rush ahead. If there is pain, they come to a standstill.

A cart is safe if the road is flat; both human mind and the society are safe when there is balance and equanimity. This is what samyayoga is.

Equilibrium should be sought in all aspects of life. It is needed in spiritual, economic and social realms also. The difference between high and low impedes the progress of the society. A bullock cart cannot move if one of the bullocks is tall and another short. Today, a few are learned while some others are illiterate. Erudition of the few is of little use in practical affairs, while the illiterate lack even rudimentary knowledge. This is not a happy situation for the society.

Not mathematical equality

I have formulated an aphorism, साम्यं समाधानम्—*samya* is that which satisfies everyone. In a family, there is love for every member, though things are not the same for all of them. When the children are small, parents have the main role. The position is reversed when the children grow up. But that in no way affects the love between them. If we attempt mathematical equality, that will make the world joyless; it will result in more harm than benefit.

I do not want mathematical equality; rather I stand for equality like that between the fingers. Our five fingers

are not equally long, but they cooperate with each other and perform countless actions. They are not equally long, but it is not that one is an inch long and another is a foot long. Their lengths are not equal, but they do not differ from each other drastically. That is what I desire.

Equality should be accompanied with wise discernment. A mother does not give her children equal food. That depends on their age, need and the capacity to digest. Such discrimination is necessary. It is inner, spiritual equality that we seek, not a mechanical one.

Spiritual basis

Samyayoga means linking everything with God. We want to create a society based on the conviction that God has pervaded and permeated the whole universe. Samyayoga, therefore, involves likening ourselves to all. What I need should be available to all. I should feed others, as I like to be fed when hungry. I should give water to others, as I like to be given water when thirsty. I should not harm others, as I do not want to be harmed. I want pleasure; therefore, I should give pleasure to others. If this principle is followed by all, all the conflicts will end and the world will veritably become heaven.

The same Self exists in all. When this is realised, nonviolence comes to stay. Then no one can harm others, as harming others amounts to harming our own Self.

Samyayoga believes that the same Self resides in all the human beings. Hence, it does not discriminate between man and man. It does not even believe that there is any basic difference between the Self in humans and in other living creatures. The only difference admitted is that in human beings the Self is capable of growth which cannot be achieved in other creatures. Even in human beings, not all can have the same degree of development, though it is possible through education in human beings. It is not so in other creatures. But, as the whole creation

is an abode of the same Self, we should, as far as possible, protect all the species.

Holistic theory

Samyayoga is a holistic theory of life. It neither opposes nor promotes any rigid set of ideas and beliefs. It is not a reaction to any ideology. We desire to build a solid foundation for life and erect the whole edifice on that foundation. It is a systematic thought, which aims to transform every aspect of life and create a new social order with the aid of science.

Samyayoga not only believes in the unity of Self, but desires to go deeper on that basis. Therefore, it has revolutionary consequences in the moral, economic, social and political realms. When we adopt a basic, spiritual thought, it enters into many a facet of life.

Revolution in all spheres

When we are spiritually one, our capacities and possessions do not belong to us, but to all. We should regard these as God-given and dedicate them to the society. Whatever may be the form of wealth, we are not its owners; we are only the trustees. Even our body is not really ours; we are its mere trustees.

When people consider themselves owners of wealth, their interests clash. But when the idea of trusteeship comes in, the whole thought process is radically altered. Complete surrender of one's narrower interests at the altar of society ensures the good of the individual. My real self-interest lies in surrendering my interests to the society and then ceaselessly striving for the good of society.

One who serves the society to one's utmost capacity earns the right to a living. Service rendered by a handicapped person may be less, yet he merits a livelihood. The idea of providing more or less sustenance according to more or less capacity to serve is wrong.

Sustenance is a physical thing; service is moral. A moral thing cannot be evaluated in terms of a physical thing.

It follows that all kinds of labour should have the same return. Today, return for physical labour is less than that for intellectual labour. The latter has also more dignity. But there is no basis whatsoever for such discrimination. There can, of course, be different kinds of service. There will be difference between the service of a mother and that of her son. There will be differences in capacities. Every finger has its own distinctive role, but all the fingers are equal. So, all should be cared for.

According to samyayoga, everyone should get opportunity for full development and education, and equal remuneration for the work done, of whatever kind it may be. If there are differences in remuneration, development will be misdirected. All kinds of labour should also have equal social status.

Everyone will be assured of work and bread. For this purpose, raw materials in the village will have to be processed in the village itself to produce finished goods, thereby achieving regional self-sufficiency. Every village will become self-reliant. Economy of a samyayogi society will be basically rural. There will be a decentralised economy. Samyayoga thus brings about revolution in the economic realm.

In the political field also, our values change when we adopt the philosophy of samyayoga. Our quest is then for a society, which is free not only from exploitation but also from the coercive power of the State. Authority of administration will be dispersed over all the villages. Every village community will have self-rule; the centre will have only nominal authority. There will be steady progress towards a State-free society.

The social sphere will be rid of caste differences and

the feeling of high and low.

Thus, samyayoga seeks to bring about transformation in economic, moral, social and political realms. It changes moral values and thereby brings about revolution in all the branches of life. This is what revolution really is.

The Gita as samyayog

Different titles have been given to the Gita, depending on different interpretations about her essence. Lokmanya Tilak called it 'Karmayoga' (yoga of selfless action). Gandhiji named it 'Anasaktiyoga' (yoga of detachment). All these names are appropriate. But if an all-inclusive name is to be given, it will have to be 'samyayoga'.

The verses 6.29 to 6.32 in the Gita⁶ give the essence of the Gita as samyayoga. They encapsulate the philosophy of a samyayogi society in a nutshell. I have derived the following conclusions from them:

1. There should not be any coercive power ruling over society. The society should be governed by noble thoughts, accepted and followed voluntarily.
2. All capacities and faculties of individuals should be surrendered to society and society should give opportunities to all the individuals for their development.

6. The actual meanings of the verses are as below:

A person, harmonised by yoga, sees the Self abiding in all beings and all beings in the Self; everywhere he sees the same.

He, who sees Me everywhere, and all in Me, will never lose hold of Me nor will I lose hold of him.

The yogi who, established in unity, worships Me abiding in all beings, abides in Me, in whatever state he may be.

He who, by likening himself with others, senses pleasures and pains for all as for himself, is considered a great yogi.

3. All services rendered honestly and sincerely and in accordance with one's capacity should have the same moral, social and economic value.⁶

The ideas of *yajna* (sacrifice), *tapas* (austerities) and *dana* (charity) in the Gita are for creating equilibrium and establishing *samyayoga*.

See the Self abiding in all beings and all beings in the Self, says the Gita (6.29). A person is not liberated by thinking that he has nothing to do with anyone and no one needs to have any concern for him. He is liberated when he realizes that he belongs to all and all belong to him.

To regard others as one's own self—all religions have held this to be the supreme moral dictum. While dealing with others, we should think what we would have felt, had we been in their position. Our behaviour towards others should be determined by what we expect from others.

We can have an idea of the feelings and needs of others from what we feel and need. Let us not consider only our body as our own; others' bodies are also ours and we should care for them. It is I who is doing everything in the form of all beings—we have to take the experience of such pervasiveness.

Our *abhidheya*

What is our *abhidheya*—the central subject of our concern and reflection? *Abhidheya* is different from both, the ultimate aim and the short-term target. It is that around which all our thinking, meditation and action revolves. It is that which defines the direction to which all our thoughts are to be turned, the organs are to be harnessed and the life is to be oriented. our *abhidheya* is *parama* (ultimate) *samya*.

The epithet '*parama*' (ultimate) is important here. We

are not concerned with only economic or social equality. Equanimity of the mind is a grade higher. But there is a third thing, which is beyond all three, and that is what we mean by ultimate *samya*. Economic equality helps in practical affairs. Social equality maintains order in the society. Mental poise, equanimity keep the mind in control. It is also extremely necessary. Without it, man would keep seeking pleasure but inevitably get grief. Control of the mind is the prerequisite for every quest—be it of knowledge, action or devotion. But the ultimate *samya* is on an even higher level. It is higher than the realm of science and the realm of ethics. It encompasses all other kinds of equalities and is far above them, and thus enters the realm of spirituality. In other words, it can be equated with Brahman⁷; nothing less than that. Let people pursue different kinds of *samya* in their lives; this pursuit would eventually lead them to the ultimate and perfect *samya*, wherein they would get established.

In reality, the ultimate *samya* is not something to be sought and achieved; it already exists in the world. It is not something to be put together on purpose. Economic and social equality and mental equanimity are things to be achieved. When we achieve them, we will have a vision of the ultimate *samya*, which was already there, but was not visible to our blind eyes.

Samanvaya

Thus, ultimate *samya* is our *abhidheya* and we want to make *samanvaya* the methodology of our thinking. In our

7. *Brahman* is the Absolute—the Supreme Truth, the Eternal and the Ultimate Reality. It pervades everything and transcends everything. It is the Supreme Self, of which individual selves are parts. Their evolution lies in merging with the *Brahman*, that is, attaining spiritual liberation.

philosophical discourse, samyayoga is the goal and *samanvaya* is the methodology, the process.

The seven notes in music appear contradictory to each other, yet they together produce melodious music. Many such examples can be given. In all such cases, contradictory nature is only apparent; reality is different. To cook rice, we need fire, water, rice and a pot. A particular sequence needs to be followed to cook rice. Only then the rice can be cooked. If any other sequence is followed, rice will not be cooked. Process is important; if it is overlooked, the four required things appear contradictory to each other. *Samanvaya* essentially means bringing together and blending apparently contradictory things. It is the main feature of Indian civilisation.

India has always believed in the synthesis of different thoughts. Whatever might have been the motive of incoming people—they might have come seeking asylum, for trade, for exchange of ideas, or might have committed aggression—India absorbed them through *samanvaya*—by accepting and assimilating whatever was worth accepting in them.

India is an ancient country with a history of several millennia. Many communities from outside came here, which inevitably resulted in conflicts. I do not think that such contacts did us harm. Whenever such contact is established, initially there are bound to be prejudices and hostility. But eventually a composite culture took shape, which had the capacity to bring about reconciliation. Harmonising all thoughts is a distinctive characteristic of India. We reject one-sided thoughts and absorb good features in different thoughts. In this manner, we proceed towards perfection. The whole development of Indian life has occurred through the process of *samanvaya*. It is the main strength of this country. We have gone on accepting the good and leaving out the bad part. This process should continue.

Equal respect for all religions is a fruit of the idea of *samanvaya* that India has given to the world. But we have still to make it a reality. I hope India will bring this about. Islam and Christianity in India will put on a new Indian garb, and Hinduism will also be purified during the encounter with them. All religions will become complementary to one another, will enrich the thought of humanity and make human life more beautiful and integrated.

Sarvodaya

Utilitarianism: a dangerous doctrine

Industrial and scientific progress in the West gave rise to a theory which advocates 'greatest good of the greatest number' and believes that the interests of a few may be sacrificed to realize it. This is a very dangerous doctrine. It has vitiated the entire spectrum of economic, social and political ideas.

It is an intolerable doctrine. It has given rise to innumerable conflicts all over the world. It has created schism between majority and minority everywhere, which is hindering establishment of peace.

It is wrong to harm the interests of one for the sake of the interests of another one, although there can be voluntary sacrifice, just as in the body, the hand may volunteer to protect the eye and get cut off. To decide whether something is conducive to the greatest good of the greatest number, the principle of majority is applied. But are the wise ever in majority? A doctrine which gives overriding importance to numbers is defective and immoral. Sarvodaya refutes this doctrine and says that we should seek and strive for the good of all.

Suppose a teacher asks her students to solve a mathematical problem. Fifteen students give a wrong answer and only two give the right answer. Do the

numbers decide the correctness of the answer of a mathematical problem? As far as the vision of truth is concerned, numbers have no significance.

We cannot assume that majority knows the truth. A single person can grasp the truth and stand against the whole society for its sake; he is entitled, even duty-bound, to do so. This is what satyagraha is about.

Harmony of interests

‘Sarvodaya’ is an apt and eloquent word, coined by Gandhiji. It is so pregnant with meaning that the more we think about it and act in its light, the more will we understand it. But one idea that it definitely conveys is that as God has created the human society, it cannot be His intention that the interests of people should differ from one another. No father wants that interests of his children should be at variance with one another. If I am healthy, it does not harm your health. Purification of my heart does not go against purification of your heart. A tiger feels that it is in its interest to pounce upon a rabbit and eat it, and a rabbit feels that it is in its interest to save itself from the clutches of a tiger. So, their interests differ. But such is not the case in human society. Thoughts may, of course, differ; it is good. They can be brought together to make a complete thought.

But it does appear that interests differ. One of the reasons is the influence of mammon. Out of ignorance or lethargy, people assume that it is in their interest to hanker after wealth or power. But it is wrong. If you give love, you will receive love. Love begets love; hatred begets hatred.

Sarvodaya says that the very constitution of the creation is such that interests of human beings cannot collide with one another. So, if we take care of others, interests of all will be served. I should, therefore, care for you and you should care for me. But the question arises, what if you do not care for me even if I care for you?

This is how people think. India does not want to increase army, but thinks that as Pakistan is increasing army, she would have to follow suit. This means that we have given Pakistan the capacity to make us dance to its tune. We have given others power to make us good or evil. Initiative is not in our hands. Others would mould our behaviour. But we must not let go the initiative. It is in the nature of water to quench thirst. It quenches thirst of a cow as well as that of a tiger. It does not let others influence its nature. Sarvodaya also keeps initiative in its hands. It believes in doing good unilaterally. I will care for you irrespective of whether you care for me or not. We can have the desired results only when we make such a firm decision.

My self-interest is not different from the interests of the society. In fact, I should not have any separate self-interest apart from serving the society. My (spiritual) quest need not be apart from the service of the society. It is subsumed under it. There can be nothing like ‘my’ spiritual quest; spiritual quest means the effacement of ‘I’. In this way, sarvodaya resolves the contradiction in life. Differences between the interests of the individuals and of the society cease to exist. Pursuit of self-interest and spiritual pursuit become one. Sarvodaya is, thus, an irreproachable and auspicious thought, which eliminates all sorts of inequalities and effaces the difference between the self-interest of individuals and the highest good of all.

Why do we think that we should look after our own self-interest? Why do we separate our self-interest from the interest of others? If I look at my self-interest as something apart from the interests of others, it would not serve my self-interest. If I close the doors of my house and do not allow the air inside to go out, I also prevent the air outside from coming in. Do I gain or lose thereby? My self-interest lies in opening the doors of my house. Thereby, whatever belongs to me becomes common

property of the world and whatever belongs to the world becomes mine. Our true self-interest lies in caring for the whole of the society. The society, an embodiment of the Lord, will also then care for us.

In fact, an ideal society is like the human body. Its various limbs function together instinctively and naturally and have a sympathetic relationship with each other. The eye feels a prick on the foot. The same phenomenon is seen in some measure in a family. A child is, in a way, a non-entity; it makes no tangible contribution to the family. Yet if it is ill, every member of the family is worried. A community can also live happily and prosper if there is sympathy and fellow-feeling for one another in it.

Opposition to parochialism

The philosophy of sarvodaya is, on the whole, harmonising and synthesising, which means that it is capable of bringing together and reconciling different thoughts. The principle of synthesis is, in fact, deeply etched on the Indian psyche. It can reach perfection through the ideology of sarvodaya. There should thus be no reason for sarvodaya to oppose anything. But it is certainly opposed to all those who stand for the good of a few only or believe that some castes or races are superior and should rule over others. And this opposition is such that it can never come to an end. These two ideologies are going to fight to the finish. Sarvodaya is bound to oppose casteists and communalists and all those who stand for the good of a particular class—majority or minority—and think that it is all right not to care for others, or even annihilate others if need be. If it does not, what else could be its *raison de'tre*? But this exception apart, all other strands of thought can get assimilated in sarvodaya.

The question of incentive

Sarvodaya means the good of all, equal concern for all and equal love for all. Let us love all just as a mother

loves all her children equally, and create a social order consistent with it. Some people argue that such a social order would lack incentive for putting in efforts; people toil more if there is hope for them to earn more. But this is not true. In a family, the father works more; does he work more to have more bread? In a family, consumption is not related to earnings. Every member of the family has equal right on family's earnings. Yet, enthusiasm to work does exist.

Some people counter that the case of family is different; in society, people would work more only if they are going to have more enjoyment. I hold this to be a vicious thought. It is true that this is a current trend. But then, so many evils are current in the society. This thought does not boost the desire for work; it rather boosts acquisitiveness, which leads to lethargy which, in turn, weakens the motivation to work. It is, therefore, a delusion to think that equal enjoyment would discourage motivation to work. Big nations are under a delusion that producing atom and hydrogen bombs would prevent war and keep peace. Another delusion is that more medicines would lead to better health. Capitalist society abounds in such delusions. As long as human beings are not free from these delusions, they would not experience true freedom, true liberation.

Sarvodaya: a meaningful word

The idea that we should serve the interests of all is a part of our tradition. It is also found in the Bible. Based on that, Ruskin wrote 'Unto this last'. Gandhiji paraphrased that book and titled it 'Sarvodaya'. The book upholds the principle that everybody's human rights are the same. This is what Gandhiji called 'sarvodaya'.

It has been suggested that the word 'antyodaya' (rise, uplift of the last man in the society) should be preferred over the word 'sarvodaya'. In fact, the idea of uplifting

the last man is the basis of sarvodaya. Uplifting the last man is certainly essential; the rest may wait. Still I would prefer the word 'sarvodaya', for it includes 'antyodaya'. The latter may convey that only the last man needs to be uplifted, not others; their rise has already taken place. But that is not the case. In this miserable world, everyone is in need of uplift. The intellect of the rich has become dull and lustreless because of accumulation of money. They need to be uplifted just like the hungry ones. So, it is better to use the word 'sarvodaya', although there should be special concern for the last man.

I agree that the villagers may find the word 'sarvodaya' a little difficult. Yet I have to say that this word should be used. The word 'satyagraha' too was difficult when it was suggested, but its practice made it intelligible. This will happen with 'sarvodaya' too. Besides, 'sarvodaya' is not an altogether new word. Gandhiji had used it for the translation of Ruskin's 'Unto this last'. The monthly magazine started for the propagation of Gandhiji's thoughts was also named 'Sarvodaya'. It is not quite objectionable if words conveying distinctive meanings are difficult, as they offer an opportunity to reach the hearts of the masses while explaining them. I should certainly not, and would not, use difficult words while explaining such words.

Import of sarvodaya

The idea of sarvodaya also motivates us to earn our living through the sweat of our brow. We should not be a burden on others. And, laying hands on others' money through cunning is not real earning. What we actually produce is what we really earn. Caring for others and doing productive labour are the two basic rules that we should follow. That would propagate the philosophy of sarvodaya.

I am a part of everyone and everyone belongs to me—this is what sarvodaya holds. When self-interest

becomes all-encompassing, it gets purified. Then it becomes conducive to the interests of all. If a contagious disease spreads in the village, it spares no one. Let it, therefore, be understood that we are not separate from the society. Society and individual are not different entities. All personal work should be done with a social outlook and all social work should give opportunity to individuals for their development.

Anyone with a humane attitude would desire everyone's good. But all desire their own good as well. How to reconcile these two desires? The question is— which of the two comes first? If we give priority to the good of all, then that attitude is in consonance with sarvodaya. An adherent of sarvodaya believes that his good is contained in the good of all; he does not desire his good unless and until the good of all is achieved. A mother does not have her meals before her children. This is the sarvodaya spirit, though it is limited to her children. The point is that one should be ready to sacrifice for the good of others, and feel delight in the outward suffering associated with it. This is what sarvodaya means.

Unity of life

In sarvodaya, there is no fragmentation of life. There is no conflict between individual and society, no antagonism between individual life and social life, no split between service and reflection. Service should be accompanied with reflection and reflection should provide service. This is the beauty in the practice of sarvodaya.

Sarvodaya avers the indivisible unity of life. It refuses to divide life in watertight compartments. It does not divide life in opposite categories like individual versus society, society versus State, national versus international, secular versus religious, individual liberation versus social progress. These divisions are unreal and mischievous.

They have created the present chaos. There is one law and one way, which is universally valid. What is good for the individual is good for the society. There is no real conflict of interests. Well-being is indivisible. True progress means progress of all. One man's loss cannot be another man's gain. All existence is one.

Sarvodaya gives highest value to the individual. Any idea first occurs to an individual, only thereafter it spreads in the society.

There cannot be any antagonism between society and individual, as their relationship is like the relationship between the body and its organs. A body cannot do without a hand, and a hand cannot do anything if it is severed from the body. No organ can do anything if severed from the body. Individual and society are like warp and woof. Sarvodaya, therefore, enjoins all to offer whatever land, wealth, labour, intellect or love they have to the society, to the Lord; and the society should give equal opportunity to all as regards education, security, nourishment and development.

Sarvodaya believes that there is a fundamental unity in this vast universe. All humanity is in one boat. One can be happy to the extent one exerts oneself for the good of others. The whole world is one and we must think and work for the good of all.

The programme

Gandhiji has proposed a constructive programme, which can help us advance towards sarvodaya. It is an excellent and comprehensive programme⁸, which takes into account the needs of the present as well as of the

8. Gandhiji had proposed 18-point constructive programme for the revitalisation of rural India. Readers may refer to his booklet 'Constructive Programme' (Ahmedabad: Navajivan).

future. Theory without the backing of practice is a castle in the air, while practice without the foundation of theory cannot cause progress. Theory and practice should come together. Human form denotes the same thing: legs are firmly on the ground while the head is high up in the air. As the programme has been well specified, there is no doubt about how to proceed in life. Gandhiji did not propose all the programmes all at once. He proposed any programme only after taking it up. Any programme should be such as to cater to a particular felt need at present, only then it can be carried out selflessly.

But even the theory and the practice together do not make a thought complete; that needs to be complemented with the pursuit of purification of life. Gandhiji proposed eleven vows: truth, nonviolence, non-possession, control of the palate, fearlessness etc. Life should be built on the foundation of certain faith. A river flows in a particular direction, so its water does not get diverted and it can do many things. The river of life should also flow in accordance with a set plan and activity should be based on certain postulates. This is the purpose behind these vows.

During this pursuit, our efforts prove to be inadequate and the need for devotion and prayer arises. Thus, the philosophy which seeks to realize the good of all, the constructive programmes, and practice of vows backed by devotion constitute our three-fold vision of life.

Effort for internal purification without bothering about the world outside on the one hand and the effort to change external conditions without paying any attention to the inner world—these two positions are well-intentioned, but one-sided, and would not, therefore, succeed. Both efforts should be done simultaneously. In this process, we can get help from science and spirituality. Sarvodaya means all-round development with this help.

Ends and means

Many righteous persons have taught that one should tread on the path of goodness, yet man is still not convinced that good begets good only. He is still trying to find out whether evil could sometimes breed goodness. He does believe in the veracity of the dictum 'as you sow, so you reap', as he has no experience to the contrary. Yet he is not fully convinced about it in the realm of ethics.

Some people who consider themselves pragmatic fully subscribe to unadulterated goodness, but in individual life only. They believe that one must follow pure morality in individual life, that can even ultimately lead to spiritual liberation; but some admixture of good and evil is unavoidable in social life. Gandhiji never accepted this idea. He made us apply fundamental principles like truth and nonviolence at the social level, as a result of which we attained Independence. A theorem, which is true for one triangle, is true for all triangles. If absolute morality leads to the well-being of an individual, it must be conducive to the well-being of society.

Some people think that it is sufficient if the desired end is in tune with the truth; then the means do not matter. But Gandhiji consistently opposed this notion. He held that swaraj could be attained through truthful means only; swaraj gained through pure means would be true swaraj. One should think more about the means than the end. The end comes in sight when the means are fully applied. Difference between ends and means is imaginary. It is not only true that the end is attained through the means; it is also true that the nature of end depends on the means. Everyone thinks that his or her objects are good. So, the claim of having a good object does not matter much. There should not be contradiction between the end and the means. This is not a new idea. But the scale on which Gandhiji applied this idea in India in

practice has no other parallel.

Some others say, insistence on goodness is all right, but it is more important to remain active under all circumstances. If the insistence on goodness becomes a hindrance in the way of remaining active, we should prefer activity over insistence on goodness. I think this is a fallacy. When people had to serve long sentences during the freedom struggle, it used to be called 'rotting in jails'. Gandhiji then used to point out that there is great power in the inactivity of a pure soul. The Gita has termed it, in her inimitable style, 'action in inaction'. Activity indeed is valuable, but truth and goodness are even more valuable than activity. One may remain inactive in certain situations, but must never give up truth.

Some persons, who call themselves pragmatic, endorse truth, but think that unilateral adherence to truth is risky. They say that we would suffer if we continue to cling to truth and nonviolence when our opponent is resorting to untruth and violence. These people do not know the value of truth. Otherwise, they would not have so argued. They do not argue, 'Our adversary is starving; so why should we eat?' They know that whosoever eats would gain strength. Unilateral eating is all right for them, but not unilateral adherence to truth. What does this mean? This means that we would imitate the opponent; we would place initiative in his hands. This is a timid notion, which creates a vicious circle. Evil is having a field day. We should have the guts to stop it. We should steadfastly stick to love and large-heartedness without caring for the consequences. After all, truth, love and goodness are positive qualities; untruth and such qualities are negative. What does light have to fear in its battle against darkness?

Mission for the age

Sarvodaya is no less profound than any spiritual doctrine preceding it. Philosophers in the East and in the

West have put forward many doctrines. Sarvodaya is more profound than all these doctrines as it not only touches all the aspects of life, but also transforms them completely. Sarvodaya is the synthesis of spirituality and science.

Just as people worked together to achieve freedom, we should have now before our eyes a constructive, positive aim of universal well-being. Whatever we think, reflect upon, write and work, all that should be for the achievement of this aim only. Let all our faculties be harnessed towards this very purpose and let us work for it vigorously. Then I have no doubt that the aim would be achieved.

After the attainment of Independence, we need to have a lofty aim, which can inspire us in individual and social life. Sarvodaya is such an aim.

In sarvodaya, many one-sided thoughts can come together, get fused together to create a whole. It is the philosophy of this age. No other ism—communism, socialism, capitalism or welfare-Statism—can satisfy the urges of this age. Sarvodaya aims to convert a village into a city and city into a village. It asks Brahmins to become manual labourers and asks the labourers to acquire knowledge. It asks men to imbibe the qualities of women and undertake jobs being done by them presently and asks women to take up the responsibility of public affairs. Sarvodaya means to make up what one lacks. It will take everyone to perfection.

Sarvodaya wants to accomplish the revolutionary work of ending private ownership. It asserts that the present social order is an untruth. It must be changed. It should be—nay, it would be—changed through nonviolence alone. Capitalists rely on money-power and the power of arms. They who use the same means cannot finish off capitalism; they can only produce another kind of capitalism. Capitalists want to sustain ownership by

means of violence. If we seek to end ownership by means of violence, there would not be revolution in means. Revolution will take place only when both the ends and the means are transformed.

Our responsibility

Those who have accepted a philosophy like sarvodaya, which claims to bring about change in hearts, have to try to dive deeper than the saints of yore. The claim of those saints was limited to internal purification; their service to society was incidental. They thought that such service would touch the people, which would eventually purify the society. But we talk of changing the social order, of transforming the entire life, of creating a new universal human being. When we speak such language, it becomes incumbent on us to go deeper spiritually.

We are being tested in this short life. We should realise this and serve all, love all and earn the love of all before we depart. One who has earned money in this world, but has lost love, has gained nothing. One who has earned knowledge, but not love, has gained nothing. One who has earned strength, but not love, has gained nothing. Love all and earn the love of all—this is the message of sarvodaya.

I am a part of all and all are in me—I cannot, therefore, resort to falsehood in my personal life, in business transactions, in social intercourse; in fact, anywhere. If I am everywhere, falsehood would be unseemly. What to hide and from whom? Aren't I and one from whom I want to hide one and the same?

We should, therefore, fortify our commitment to truth and nonviolence. We should jealously guard against the entry of violence in our life. And we should carry out different constructive programmes along with friends or

by forming an institution if need be. We should constantly keep alive the spirit of sarvodaya in mind and speech.

Firm commitment to Truth is the foundation of sarvodaya. Some people are apprehensive lest it should deter many from joining the sarvodaya fraternity. But why can't all have incentive for goodness? I would cherish the hope that they would have such incentive. But even if they do not have it and sarvodaya remains an unmanifest idea, even that idea would promote well-being of the whole world.

2

Process of Revolution

Three kinds of work

Three kinds of work need to be undertaken in the world. The first is the purification of social mind. A lot of vitiating factors are at work in the society. It is a primary duty of the society to ensure that the process of purification continues unabated. Gandhiji used to insist that every work should result in the purification of mind. It is in this view that he prescribed eleven vows for the ashram inmates.

The second work is to create a spirit of love and mutual cooperation. This is particularly essential in India where people belong to different castes, religions and linguistic groups. It is our bounden duty to avert collision of interests and nurture love so as to make it the foundation of society.

The third work is to root out conventional values to pave way for social progress. This is a kind of educative work. Traditional values bind even noble minds, not to speak of average minds.

Four impelling forces

Four impelling forces are always active in the world. The first is that of self-interest. This impulse is always present in human beings in varying degrees, and it would always be present. It is necessary for an individual for carrying out personal affairs and for the development of individuals, and therefore would and should exist forever. But this impulse should go on getting refined more and more day by day. It should not go against the higher impulse in the human beings and should eventually merge into that impulse. The more it goes against the higher impulse, the more trouble it would create. But in

conjunction with the higher impulse, it is beneficial to both the individual and the society. It would not then create any difficulty.

History testifies that this impulse of self-interest has been evolving and getting purer as a result of reflection and experience. And this is exactly what should happen.

The second one is the social impulse—an impulse that drives all the individuals in a society at a given time. Presently, the drive for national Independence and national unity is strong everywhere. Patriotic feelings were never so prominent and powerful. If the impulse of self-interest goes against this social impulse, it cannot survive. And if the impulse for national independence and unity goes against the individual self-interest, it would spell trouble. The two impulses need to be in harmony with each other.

The third impelling force is that of science. We may call it the force of the demands of the age or demands of the time. It is wrong to presume that science is for the use of human beings. Science can be and is useful to human beings, but it is not shaped by human necessity. Scientific discoveries have not taken place out of necessity. Science has its own independent dynamics. A human being has natural curiosity for knowledge. It is because of his brain cells. It is true that governments have compelled the scientists to work on particular projects, but the scientists are naturally inclined to work without thinking about potential utility. Science cannot be controlled by human beings; it cannot be their tool. It is for us to adapt ourselves and our social structure to science.

This force of science is in ascendance now. If the impulse of self-interest and the national impulse go against the force of science, that too would spell trouble.

Besides these, I think the force of Divinity is also

working in the world. It is striving to make the world a single family. It is this force, which is making people work for a universal religion, a world State, a global system of justice. I also foresee the development of a single language for mutual dealings. There could be conflicts, but ultimately all the other forces would have to adapt themselves to the force of Divinity.

Harmony between these forces is essential for sustaining the society and maintaining balance in it. If they collide with each other, society would be doomed. Our every step should therefore be with a view to achieve harmony between these forces.

Elimination of caste differences

When we take the name of 'sarvodaya', it implies removal of all kinds of differences. Caste differences is one such kind. Let it be clearly understood that they are not a part of Hindu dharma. Hindu dharma prescribes varna system⁹, and there is absolutely no relation between caste and varna. Caste differences are a blot on Hindu dharma. The differences of high-and-low that they create conflicts and prevent consolidation of society. They obstruct creation of community, and without a community, societal work is impossible. Caste differences hinder our progress at every step. They are a major roadblock in the evolution of gram-swaraj (village self-rule), which is imperative in this age of science. They must, therefore, go lock, stock and barrel.

It is essential that caste differences should be severed from Hindu dharma and then attacked; not as a part of

9. Division of society into four divisions or *varnas* : *Brahmin* (teachers, priests, intellectuals), *Kshatriya* (warriors, administrators, kings), *Vaishya* (those engaged in trading, farming, animal husbandry) and *Shoodra* (artisans and those doing manual work).

Hindu dharma. I have read the scriptures and affirm solemnly that there is no support for caste distinctions in Hindu dharma. If they are considered an integral part of Hindu dharma, they would never go away; instead they would be strengthened.

For the elimination of caste differences, it is important to have constructive attitude and goodwill. Superficial efforts would lead us nowhere. This evil can never be ended by force and violence. Love, that is, the feeling of social solidarity alone can destroy it. Education is the main remedy. Secondly, they should be neglected and bypassed. Caste should not be a point of consideration for marriage. We should not ask anyone what his or her caste is, and if anyone asks us our caste, we should refuse to reply. Non-vegetarianism is one of the reasons for the evolution of castes. It should be given up. Caste distinctions are related to the question of physical labour and its dignity. The way out is to accept the dignity of physical labour and give it a just return.

We should serve all without any distinction. It should be propagated that a village is a single unit. When private property in land is abolished (through gramdan), everyone in the village is given some land, gram-sabha becomes the vehicle for gram-swaraj, people start coming together for collaboration in economic activities and spiritual matters, caste differences would get progressively weakened. Gram-swaraj is the panacea for all the ills plaguing the village community. It strikes at the root of all miseries and problems.

Our approach

A lamp continues to burn when there are no strong air currents in the vicinity; otherwise, it would be extinguished. A lamp is extinguished even if there are no air currents, if the oil gets exhausted. Just as a lamp needs oil, a human being needs faith and devotion within his

heart. And just as a lamp needs calm surroundings, there has to be peace in society. Only when human hearts are full of devotion and the society is peaceful, the light of knowledge can spread far and wide. Then both the individual and social life would be illumined. It is in this view that sarvodaya pays attention to both the aspects: purity of individuals and peace in society.

Saints have tried to transform the human heart. They created faith in the minds of the people. Their influence still persists. The communists tried to create a society free from exploitation and poverty. We seek to work for both the individual and the social transformation simultaneously. Individuals influence society and society influences individuals. We, therefore, work with a two-pronged approach for a fundamental and permanent change.

Conflict is not the way

These days, the philosophy of conflict has gained wide currency. I have read and heard about it a lot, but I do not think that it is suitable for India. We should instead adopt the philosophy of churning. Not friction but churning is the need of the day. Churning produces butter, while friction results in heat, and consequently dissipation of energy.

Revolution would take place neither through love nor through conflict. Only thoughts can bring about a revolution. Friction weakens both the parties, and love can at best enthuse people. Only ideas can cause revolution. I, therefore, pin my faith on the dissemination of thoughts. I would certainly not shy away from conflict if it becomes necessary for the propagation of thoughts. But it is not conflict that brings about revolution. Shankaracharya believed in transformation in thinking through explanation of his ideas and viewpoint. He would meet pious and virtuous individuals, convert them to his view and

propagate righteousness through them. I concur with this approach. Once people accept the ideas, they would automatically put them into practice. We should act like a signpost; it is for the people to follow the road they prefer.

This approach of Shankaracharya is worth emulation by all. It is this approach which avoided conflicts. In Europe, the Church opposed scientific discoveries. Nothing like that happened in India. Shankaracharya's approach ensured independence of thought and action.

Transformation of values is one thing; making people happy is another. We seek the former. Such transformation is what I call peaceful revolution. In fact, the adjective 'peaceful' is unnecessary, as a revolution is necessarily peaceful. Values change only in a peaceful manner.

Rather than involving ourselves in an attempt to remove each and every injustice, we should concentrate on positive, constructive work.

Lesser activity, more action

We should work in such a way as to avoid entanglement in work. It is for the people to take up the work of altering their condition. We should only motivate and guide them.

Potency of action increases in proportion to the reduction in the intensity of activity. Lesser the activity, more is the work. Gross activity cannot be avoided by human beings in their present condition, but it is desirable that gross activity should go on reducing progressively and the mental goodwill should go on doing more and more work. I believe that thinking about the good of others is more effective than doing good to them. People are under the impression that speech is more powerful than thinking and action is more powerful than speech. But when mind becomes a naught, speech is more

powerful than action and thinking is more powerful than speech.

We should, therefore, adopt a process wherein intensity of activity gets progressively reduced and thinking goes on increasing.

Power of words

I believe in the power of words. Weapons make their appearance when this power gets paralysed. Power of words depends on two factors. First, our speech should authentically convey what we mean, what we have in mind. It is believed that politicians do not mean what they say; they have something else in mind. Their words cannot, therefore, carry conviction. Secondly, the words should have the capacity to rouse the people. It depends on the penance behind our words.

I, therefore, keep on telling the workers that they should meditate over the word 'sarvodaya' while working. Such words inspire and strengthen us. I have more faith in words than organisations.

An expert engineer designs the road to the hilltop in such a way that we advance towards the top without realising that we are ascending a hill. It is a characteristic of revolutionary thought that it skilfully introduces new ideas in an old concept. The word remains the same, but its meaning undergoes change. Revolution should be accomplished in such a way that the stream of the tradition of knowledge, which is a legacy of the past, continues to flow.

We should not, therefore, abandon old words; we should instead reinforce them with new meanings. Otherwise, we would lose our weapons one by one. Grafting gives new vigour to an old plant. This should be done with words too. This has been an accepted process in India. This is how a nonviolent revolution proceeds.

Not attack but offering

The process of purification of individual and social life should go on unabated. During this process, defects are inevitably attacked. But though the attack may be well-intentioned, it does have some adverse effect. We would have to devise a process which would lead to purification, to the removal of defects while avoiding head-on collision with them. It is particularly necessary in this age of science, as the world has become a little nest.

Many great men have in the past attacked the defects in society for the sake of social reform. But now we would have to initiate a different process. It is not attack (*prahar*) but a benevolent spirit of helping others (*upahar*) that should mark our approach. We should place our thoughts before others for consideration. Presently, different cultures, civilisations, thought currents are clashing with one another. In such a scenario, any attack would invite reactions and would prove to be counter-productive. Situation needs more gentleness, more subtlety. Such process needs to be explored and developed. This is what I am attempting.

Cooperation between five forces

Five forces need to be strong in society, and there should be close cooperation between them. Only then could individual and society remain healthy.

The first one is like the thumb. The thumb is strong. I liken it with the people's power. I have thought a lot about building up the people's power. It entails making every village a single family and foster the spirit of gram-swaraj—autonomy and self-reliance of the village community.

The second one is like the little finger. I liken it with the power of the good in society—in other words, the power of selfless workers who have based their lives on

fundamental moral values like truth and nonviolence and who serve the people in the light of those values. It has been my hope that a community of the virtuous in the society would eventually take shape.

The third one is like the index finger. It shows the way. I have termed it the 'power of the learned and the wise'. The wise and learned individuals are expected to study the happenings in the world objectively and present their considered opinion before the people. This power is expected to go on gaining strength, with increasing influence on both the State and the civil society.

The fourth one is the power of the businessmen and entrepreneurs. It is said that common people follow this class.

The fifth finger is like the ring finger—it does not have any particular function like other fingers. It is supposed to cooperate with other fingers. The power of the State is like this finger. It should carry out only those residual functions which are not performed by other powers.

However, this power has now become supreme—not only in India, but everywhere in the world. It has strangled the world in its clutches. The power of nonviolence alone is able to wither away the State. As the sarvodaya society is gradually built up, the power of the State is expected to wane correspondingly and be eventually reduced to a nominal existence.

Cooperation between these five powers is essential for a healthy society. There should be mutual trust between various components of the society. Then alone could the world be peaceful and prosperous.

Sanskrit word for 'trust' is '*vishwas*', which has been derived from '*shwas*', that is, breath. Trust is as important in social life as breathing is for the individual's life.

Without mutual trust between its various components, society is as good as dead.

Five objections against my strategy

Five objections have repeatedly been raised against my strategy since the inception of the Bhoodan Movement.

The first one is that I do not undertake satyagraha; satyagraha would infuse zeal and ardour in the Movement, and without it the Movement would run out of steam. My contention is that the so-called satyagrahas in these days lack truth; they reveal insistence only. The term 'satyagraha' has, as a result, got degraded. It has been disgraced. I do not believe in such satyagrahas. I do not foresee any efficacy in them. I have been carrying out the satyagraha of my conception continuously and expect it to resist all kinds of injustice. Fasting is no more an effective technique, having been blunted by repeated use. This is my answer to the first objection.

The second objection is that I neglect the political aspect. But I have advanced the concept of lokniti¹⁰ in this connection. I am firmly convinced that conventional politics is on its way out. It has become outdated. We are endeavouring to transform conventional politics into lokniti. The key to the solution of all problems lies in lokniti.

The third objection is that I am concentrating on securing more and more gramdans instead of developing the villages that have opted for gramdan, and that it is not a proper strategy; we should also create some models. But the point is that the process of development is necessarily a continuous one, which would go on ad

infinitum. This process would get a firm foundation and right direction from the programme of gramdan alone. We have seen what is the result of development without the foundation of gramdan.

The fourth objection is that I do not pay any attention to the common problems of the general public. Many believe that day-to-day problems of the people should be taken in hand. But I assert that I am engaged in dealing with the foundation of all problems. The present situation demands such an approach, and not a shallow one.

The fifth objection is that although I talk of '*Jai Jagat*' (Victory to the world), my approach is not global; it betrays nationalistic sentiments. But India is the world in miniature, and creation of a pan-Indian outlook would inevitably lead to the creation of a global identity; and that is what I am engaged in.

These have been my replies to the objections raised with regard to my strategy. Had I found any substance in any of them, I would certainly have changed my strategy accordingly.

10. The readers may refer to Vinoba's 'Swaraj and Lokniti' (Varanasi: Sarva Seva Sangh Prakashan, 2014) for elaboration of the concept of lokniti, which is Vinoba's alternative to conventional democratic politics.

3

Organisation: Test of Nonviolence

Why I left institutions?

I love solitude. But in jail, I had contact with all sorts of people. I found that every group or party had both good and bad people in its ranks in the same proportion. I, therefore, came to the conclusion that I should serve the good people without joining any party or institution. After my release, I put this idea before Gandhiji, who said in his characteristic language, "I understand what you mean. You will serve, but without any post or privilege. It is okay." I then resigned from all the institutions with which I was associated. It was painful, as they were very dear to me; I had been striving for years to fulfil their objectives. But I was also delighted. I was going to continue to help those institutions, though I wanted to be free for the sake of development of nonviolence.

Association with an organisation circumscribes and conditions our thinking and it is not conducive to the quest for nonviolence. For new exploration, objectivity is a must. A member of an organisation cannot have such objectivity, even if he may do much work. New discoveries cannot be made with a conditioned mind.

If we seek organisation instead of concerning ourselves with free dissemination of our ideas, we would restrict ourselves to a small circle. But I do not want this. Khadi-wearers and non-khadi-wearers, drinkers and teetotallers—all are mine and I am theirs. I want to identify with all. This is not possible if I am within the bounds of an organisation.

These days, many appear interested in organising people, instead of awakening human heart. However, one can organise commodities, not humans. Human being can be educated. When we seek to organise human beings, we

are treating them as commodities. Thereby we restrict the spread of ideas, rather than accelerating them.

However, had I been convinced that every institution invariably has some element of violence in it, I would have advised others also to keep away from any institution. But that is not the case. We are, for example, convinced that arms invariably involve violence; but I have not come to the conclusion that any institution necessarily involves violence. An individual has some violence in him, but when two good individuals come together, violence in both of them gets reduced.

However, when we form an institution, bound by certain discipline whose breach invites disciplinary action, there is possibility of violence. But if one is free to join it or not, that is another matter. If a person joins an institution of his own free will and yet flouts its discipline, the institution can justifiably take action against him. But when discipline itself is absent, there is no question of violence.

Defects and limitations

Society should be properly organised. But it should be natural like a family. When people come together for sectarian considerations, their capacity to do good does not get enhanced. If they come together in a fraternal spirit, consider a human being more important than his opinions and inner attitude more important than external actions, look upon a human being as a human being only, the capacity to do good increases. I know many institutions, which were established with lofty objectives, but flaws crept in them eventually. And then there is a tendency to cover up those flaws. Fragmentation also follows.

I, therefore, have more faith in uttering truth than in organisations. It is not that organisations will always be unnecessary; if a man clings to truth, necessary

organisation takes shape of its own accord. But deliberate creation of organisations narrows our vision.

Strength lies not in organisation, but in truth. Sarvodaya discerns this. It is not under the illusion that organisation of weaknesses results in strength. Such an idea is a flight of fancy of lazy minds. Had collection of diseases resulted in health, there would have been no need of medicines and medical practitioners, or nutritious food!

Just as a human being has a body and a soul, an institution too has a body and a soul. Its soul is the principles at its foundation. This soul should keep on evolving. Body and institution—both can be helpful, and both can be hindrances too. It needs ingenuity to make them helpful. As far as the external structure is concerned, one need not have any insistence. But the foundation must be steadfastly held on to.

Local, small-scale organisations need not be ruled out. In such organisations, every individual would fully know all the other members. There would be little scope for hypocrisy and vanity. Such organisations can, and should, be dissolved when their utility is over.

Nonviolent organisation

A nonviolent organisation would be of a very different type; so different that to call it an 'organisation' would be a misnomer. In a nonviolent organisation, advice is given. Those to whom it appeals follow it—and follow it resolutely—because it has appealed to them and has not been forced upon them. This creates a strong organisation. In other organisations, not advice but command is given, which has to be obeyed. It cannot be said that the command is obeyed with full conviction. Obedience to it is naturally half-hearted. If the command is disobeyed, disciplinary action follows. That is the usual way of

organisations. My idea is diametrically opposite. A nonviolent organisation can be strong if the advisors are wise, they follow their own advice and are capable of convincing others about the rightness of their advice. Nonviolence should demonstrate that the natural organisation that is created through it is stronger, specifically because it is natural, and not purposely formed. This is the test of nonviolence.

Pyarelalji has quoted Gandhiji in his monumental work 'The Last Phase', 'Organisation is the test of non-violence.' I would prefer the word 'planning' instead of 'organisation'. We should understand what Gandhiji wants to say here. Some people think that in this statement, Gandhiji has signified the importance of an organisation. But what Gandhiji wants to say is that nonviolence can never build up an organisation in the same manner as violence. Outside aids available to violence for organisation are not available to nonviolence. In nonviolence, no orders can be given, no punishment can be meted out, no coercive sanctions can be imposed, no enticement can be given, no medal can be offered. But in spite of this, nonviolence must have some plan to ensure that once a decision is taken, people will definitely accept it. As the advice is accepted wholeheartedly, its execution should be much more effective than the execution of an order in a violent organisation. Although the acceptance of advice is optional, in effect it should be much more imperative to follow it than a compulsory order. That which is optional is often essential. To drink water is optional, still people drink it invariably.

A nonviolent organisation will have to demonstrate that what is optional would be acted upon more conscientiously than what is compulsory. When I think about how it could be possible, I am reminded of Jesus' saying, 'Agree with thine adversary quickly.' Nonviolence

should impart the capacity to attune oneself to others.

My opposition to organisation does not mean that there is no need of concerted action. The true test of nonviolence is that while there would be complete freedom of action, it should be able to show more and better discipline than the one visible in an organisation based upon violence. In fact, violence is not intrinsically powerful. Protagonists of violence develop skill in building organisations. They erect a robust structure. And through that structure, violence is infused with the strength which it actually lacks.

The principle of unanimity in decision-making is the outward planning, while the inner planning is to rise above ego. If we keep these two things in mind and act accordingly, we will be able to build a sound and efficient nonviolent organisation.

Individual vis-à-vis organisation

I have faith in individuals, not in organisations, because an individual is full of consciousness and vitality, and a organisation is not so. An individual can have galvanizing power; an organisation does not have it. An organisation can become a 'power-house' only if individuals infuse it with such a power. Organisations cannot uplift the world; they can rather obstruct its uplift. They cannot bring about revolutions. Buddha can bring about revolution, not the Sangh. Christ can bring about revolution, not the Christian Church. Shankaracharya can bring out revolution, not the monasteries established by him. Gandhiji can bring about resolution, not the inmates of Gandhiji's ashrams. In fact, an entrenched organisation may be afraid of revolution; for it cannot go against public opinion.

Revolutions are *mantrik* (inspired by a vision) and not *tantrik* (mechanical).

Freedom from organisational structures

As gramdams picked up, I thought of the revolutionary step of discontinuing the aid being received from Gandhi Smarak Nidhi of its own accord and disbanding all Bhoodan committees to make bhoodan a people's movement (1956). Any party wants to strengthen its organisation, but we took the opposite step. A future historian, writing the history of momentous ideas, would highlight these ideas of *nidhi-mukti* (freedom from accumulated funds) and *tantra-mukti* (freedom from organisational structures).

An organisation and a movement, both are designed to materialize the ideas. Yet there is a basic difference. A movement, if properly conducted, can be instrumental in the materialization of ideas, while an organisation can encourage idolatry of the ideas. If the movement is not conducted properly, it can distort the ideas. But an organisation, even if run in a good manner, becomes, in the course of time, a rule-bound structure and loses emphasis on basic principles.

I hold that it is better to spread righteous ideas in the air. If they are sown in the soil, they will grow into a tree. But only a few persons can sit under the shadow of a tree. Its benefit is limited. But an idea, disseminated in the atmosphere, touches every heart and goes far and wide. Without this, a peaceful revolution cannot take place.

Why loss of vitality?

We find that many of our institutions appear to lack vitality. Institutions like the monasteries established by Shankaracharya have lost much of their sheen, yet they have managed to live through hundreds of years. Surely, they have something that has sustained them. Why does this not happen to our institutions? Our institutions lose their vitality before our eyes. Why do they not have continuous supply of energy?

Delving deep into the causes thereof, I have come to the conclusion that this is because of lack of philosophical depth. Our public work, therefore, gets reduced to ordinary private activity in no time. How everyone would get bread becomes the supreme concern. We do not go to the root cause of suffering. We get entangled in external work, overlooking commitment to basic principles. So, when the founder departs, the institution rapidly declines.

Financial support

We believe in non-possession at individual level, but not for institutions. Some people would not commit violence for an individual, but would not mind committing violence for the defence of society or nation. We have the same attitude as regards accumulation of money.

After Gandhiji's departure, I realized that our institutions should not be run with the support of money, as they have hitherto been. The time has changed. Now money should be avoided to the extent possible. A memorial fund was created in Gandhiji's memory (Gandhi Smarak Nidhi). But I feel that such a fund can harm rather than help the perpetuation of Gandhiji's memory. Scriptures have said, *श्राद्धान्नं न भक्षयेत्* (One should not eat the food served in the memory of a diseased person). If we run our institutions with the support of such fund, our institutions, which we expect to lead to gram-swaraj, cannot have lustre and vitality.

Some programmes like the service of lepers do need money. But, in general, not money, but labour should be the support for our institutions as well as workers. Donation should be taken only in the form of voluntary labour.

For our programmes, we may take aid from the government or some fund, but at least the livelihood of workers should not depend on such sources. We can get

government help. But I see danger in it. The scriptures frown upon the food from kings. Pandit Nehru once observed that helping a good cause was his duty. But he added, "It is noticed that such help makes the work lustreless. The government cannot refuse help, as it is its duty to help good causes." I agreed with him.

(In this connection, Vinoba made several suggestions including that of sarvodaya-patra, which has been dealt with later. In 1973, he made the following suggestion.)

Upavas-dan (Gift after fasting)

If our workers, friends and well-wishers fast for one time in a month and donate the amount so saved to sarvodaya work, it would be a great accomplishment. Such donation has three advantages. First, a person who fasts would derive spiritual benefit, for he would spend the day in reflection and introspection. He would be nearer to God. The word '*upavas*', in fact, literally means staying near to God. The second advantage is physical. Naturopaths recommend regular fasting. Fasting once in a month would certainly be beneficial. The third advantage is that such donation would be pure and sacred. It is therefore likely to be used judiciously. It would not be frittered away irresponsibly.

So far, we accepted donations freely from anyone and of any amount. I do not think that it was wrong. But now we should prefer and pursue pure means for financing our activities.

No leadership

There would be no leaders in the coming age. It is not that new leaders would replace old leaders; the coming age would be free from the leadership principle itself.

People get two things from leaders; they get specialised guidance from them and learn from them how to have a disciplined life. Both the things are necessary

for society. But leaders would not be required for this purpose in the coming age. To understand this, we would have to comprehend the nature of the age of science.

In the age of science, human beings would value knowledge more than food. Knowledge would give what leaders are giving presently. As people would work together, they would make good what is wanting in one another. Thus, different qualities would come together and carry out the function of the leaders.

After all, what does leadership mean? In the Divine scheme, every human being has one or another quality. Nobody has all the qualities and nobody is without any quality. But some individuals, having quite a few of the major endowments like knowledge, truthfulness, enterprising spirit and broad outlook, rise and become leaders. But in the new age, people would not live in isolation. They would live as part of communities. And the agglomeration of qualities would serve as a leader.

It is my prophesy that all the organisations are going to crumble under their own weight. Their foundations are going to be eroded in the age of science. Now, only two entities will exist: individual and the universe.

Submission to an individual should give place to submission to an organisation, and the latter should eventually give place to submission to principles. This is what Buddhism ordains: बुद्धं शरणं गच्छामि। संघं शरणं गच्छामि। धम्मं शरणं गच्छामि।

Not collective leadership but collective servanthood is what is needed today. I have called it *ganasevakatva*. It involves participation of all in decision-making and cooperation in the implementation of consensus, with full understanding of one's role and utility

It is not leadership, but *ganasevakatva*, which can bring about a nonviolent revolution.

4

Sarvodaya-patra

For the sake of nonviolence

After the passing away of Gandhiji, I was exploring how nonviolence could be established in India's societal life. As is well known, the incidents that took place immediately after the attainment of Independence had weakened the hope for nonviolence. That was why I was searching for ways and means for building up collective nonviolence. It was the will of God that I secured a basis for propagating nonviolence in the society, and bhoodan and gramdan¹¹ originated.

A material basis was secured for a nonviolent programme and then my concern shifted to the search for an agent to carry out the programme. In this connection, I ventured to call for the formation of Shanti-Sena—a corps of 75,000 selfless servants, one for every 5,000 of the population. The Shanti-Sainiks would work for both revolution and peace. They would serve the poor in peacetime, maintain peace and restore peace in times of disturbances even at the cost of their lives. Then we would have the agent to carry out our programme.

Different constructive programmes like khadi, village industries, basic education and removal of untouchability and caste differences are the several different actions needed in connection with the propagation of nonviolence.

And we need various means also. I have called for two kinds of means: *sampattidan* (gift of wealth) and

11. Gramdan involves voluntary surrender of landownership to the village community and the administration of village affairs by the village community by consensus. For details, see Vinoba's 'Gram-swaraj' (Village self-rule)

sammatidan (gift of consent).

Whatever wealth God has given to a person, he should enjoy it only after dedicating a portion of it to the society. No one, even a poor person, is entitled to enjoy his possessions without some sacrifice. This is what the Upanishad enjoins us to do. I have, therefore, appealed for the gift of wealth of every kind—labour, money, intellect or whatever other kind of wealth. Acceptance of this would generate a great force. And as this would be entirely voluntary, it would lead to moral uplift.

Need for consent

We have done a lot of work, but have not so far secured the consent of people for that work. We start khadi production at some place, give wages to the spinners and sell the khadi in cities. We do not take consent of the people for this work, just like businessmen. Such khadi work is like our private business. Do we go to a place to start khadi work because the people there have resolved to wear khadi? Even our intensive efforts for years could hardly make 25-30% of the local population to wear khadi. Rest of the people did not pay heed to our advice. They were perfectly entitled to do so. Everyone is free to serve. But our constructive work would generate unprecedented power only if we secure popular sanction.

We need the support of the people's consent. Such consent is not necessary for rendering ordinary service. If a good doctor is treating the people free of cost, he does not need people's consent for this service. Those who want to take his medicine would take it. But a service which is going to result in some hardships to the people and going to bring about a social revolution needs such consent. In the beginning, we offer only pain and we can offer relief only as a distant promise. It is a characteristic of pure well-being that it gives some pain initially, though the ultimate result is sweet. So, for such work, we must have people's consent.

Government builds up an army. It has your consent. Every one of you has contributed for it. Even a child is contributing, as he wears clothes and there is a tax on cloth. All of you pay taxes. They denote your consent for government's doings, right or wrong.

And what is the moral basis of that army? It is the sanction of the nation's vote. Without that, the army would be nothing but a gang of armed robbers. But the sanction of the vote is a very weak one, for a majority vote is so only in name. A government supported by say, 30% of the voters can exercise power over all the people, it is supposed to have people's mandate, and the army is accepted as national army. This is the moral authority behind it.

We, too, need a moral authority behind us. So far, we thought it sufficient to have compassion and a desire to serve the people. But we do not want to do ordinary relief work. We want to exert moral influence on the people. We would lack strength if we do not have their consent. I, therefore, call for *sammatidan* (gift of consent). It means, "We give our consent to your service and we shall do something to help you."

This is different from the vote the parties get. That vote is inactive. It only means, "We agree with your ideas. We give you the right to serve us. We are not obliged to do any more, except paying taxes." The votes do not carry with them any resolve to do anything else. We do not want the people to hand over to us the responsibility for their protection; we ask for *sammatidan* as a token of a pledge from the people that they approve of our programme and will give us some active help to carry it out.

The idea of Sarvodaya-patra

As a symbol of this, I have sought a handful of grains every day from every household. And the hand

should be that of the youngest child in the family. There is a vision behind it. Children's hands are pure, their minds are pure. If every child puts grains in Sarvodaya-patra—the pot for storing the grain so donated—for the Sarvodaya work, imagine how much power it would generate! Sarvodaya work should get help from the pure hands of the children. If their fathers or mothers give handful of grains, we would certainly get more grains. But I do not want that. Let the youngest child give. Every day, the mother will ask her child, "Have you put grains in the Sarvodaya-patra?" It will have great educative value; it would imprint the value of sharing on the child. It will teach him righteousness. And it will also give grains for our work of Bhoodan and Gramdan and Shanti-sena. It would awaken a sense of dedication in every member of the families keeping the Sarvodaya-patras and a spiritual brotherhood of such families would take shape.

Different sects have their own modes of worship. Sarvodaya-patra will establish a form of worship, which can be practised by all the children irrespective of any differences.

The idea is not entirely new. Religions also prescribe donation of a handful of grains. But such a practice has been reduced to a symbolic gesture. People are naturally reminded of such practice when they hear of Sarvodaya-patra. However, it has to be understood that this idea has taken an entirely new form. Its object is different. Grafting is done on an old tree. The idea of Sarvodaya-patra is like grafting on the old custom. That the idea is not without base is a point in its favour.

Another context

Gandhi Memorial Fund was giving aid to Bhoodan Movement as a matter of duty, as Bhoodan is Gandhiji's greatest memorial. But we discontinued their aid on our

own accord (in 1956). But some arrangement had to be made for the subsistence of selfless workers. The idea of Sarvodaya-patra has come up in this context also.

Symbol of collective resolve

Everywhere, destructive forces are on the rampage. If the world is to be saved from total ruin, collective willpower has to be developed. Power of the people, power of love will have to be pitted against the forces of destruction. People will have to make a collective resolve for the purpose. Sarvodaya-patra symbolises such resolve.

No one says that he likes violence. But violence has a special quality; there can be a collective resolve for it. Hitler orders five million soldiers to march and attack other countries, and they obey. It has to be demonstrated that a collective resolve for nonviolence is possible. India has to take lead in this respect. I have proposed Sarvodaya-patra for this very purpose. This programme will test the possibility of a collective experiment in nonviolence. Sarvodaya-patra is our means to reach every household.

Consent for Sarvodaya philosophy

Keeping Sarvodaya-patra in the house denotes consent for Sarvodaya philosophy, consent for the idea that private ownership of land should be ended through peaceful means. It shows our desire for a decentralised political order in the country. It means that we consider weapons useless in the present era of science, and are ready to contribute to the organisation of Shanti-sena.

A person who keeps a Sarvodaya-patra in his house is expected to become a fit instrument of Sarvodaya. Sarvodaya should permeate his whole being; donation of a handful of grains should be a consequence thereof. The hands, which put grain in the Sarvodaya-patra, would never indulge in stone pelting.

Sarvodaya-patra implies the commitment to live

peacefully and amicably with each other and never to do anything which is likely to disturb peace. Sarvodaya-patra is an active vote for peace.

Revolutionary programme

I am presenting nonviolent alternative to every function of violence. In an order based on violence, tax is levied on everyone. Sarvodaya-patra is an alternative to tax. There is an element of compulsion in the tax, so the people try to evade taxes. Sarvodaya-patra is kept willingly. *I want love in the place of violence, compassion in the place of law, gifts in the place of loans, Sarvodaya-patra in the place of tax, Shanti-sena in the place of army, and voluntariness in the place of compulsion.* When voluntariness becomes more powerful than compulsion, nonviolence will be firmly established.

We will get a daily vote in the form of handful of grains, whereas parties seek vote only once in five years. If we can make people accept this thought of daily contribution in India, we need not have to take the reins of government in our hands; the government will be under our control. Thus the Sarvodaya-patra possesses the power to uproot politics.

Not a climbdown

The programme demands that we should go to the people regularly. I look upon it as a model of gentle satyagraha.

When I talk of a handful of grains, people say, "You used to ask for one-sixth share of one's income and even talk of surrendering ownership. You started with such lofty ideas and have now come down to a handful of grains! What a great climbdown! You are now asking a handful of grains even from a multi-millionaire!" The point is, even if a small thing is universalised, that creates a great power. Not everyone can give land-gift. Only the

wealthy can give money. But a handful of grains can be given by every household. Let everyone give it; for extremely poor families, let their neighbours contribute partially. That will create pressure from below. The programme, I therefore assert, is not a climbdown.

Sarvodaya-patra and the workers

As a Sanskrit adage goes, when we plant a mango tree for its fruits, we get several other benefits as well. The main purpose behind Sarvodaya-patra is to secure popular sanction for our work, but provision of subsistence to the workers for peace and sarvodaya is its by-product. It is most befitting to provide subsistence to the workers through Sarvodaya-patra rather than through any other means. Not every worker can get help from his friends. Moreover, securing subsistence from the common folk is strengthening. Workers are not expected to beg. They will have commitment to physical labour. They will serve all. But to evaluate their labour in terms of money and expecting them to subsist on that much only implies acceptance of the present social and economic norms. It is wrong to expect the workers to earn their living through their own labour.

The idea of Sarvodaya-patra makes the workers strive to become worthy of people's expectations. Subsistence provided by the people with love and faith would purify the lives of workers.

The greatest idea

When the idea of Sarvodaya-patra occurred to me, I felt that I had become a seer! It was a different thing when I got the first land-gift. Then I did not have a vision; I felt that it was God's will and I was His instrument. But the idea of Sarvodaya-patra came to me as a vision, in the way visions come to the seers. If someone asks me which my greatest idea is, I will say that it is that of Sarvodaya-patra.

5

Purity and Orderliness in Life

Importance of regularity

We find many natural phenomena taking place every day with regularity. The sun rises and sets daily, not once in a week. This regularity conveys an important principle—if we want to give place to something in our life, it should be made a part of our daily routine. Such regularity is more important than reading many books, as it disciplines the organs. The sense organs should be so disciplined that the eyes do not, of their own accord, see evil; the ears do not likewise hear evil of their own accord and the tongue instinctively refrains from uttering anything foul. This can happen only when the sense organs are so trained through regular practice. Every organ should be under control. Control involves restraining them from doing any wrong and harnessing them in doing good. These two qualities are called dispassion and discrimination. These are two means for conquering the mind.

We should realise that we have nothing more than a day in our hands, and should therefore keep a proper record of it. Time is more important than money. And so one should scrupulously keep track of the time spent, just as we keep track of the expenditure of money. In fact, it is more important, as money lost can be regained, but time lost cannot be so regained.

If we fix time for some activities in the daily routine, then other activities become regular as a matter of course. The day should therefore be started with a particular activity.

Regularity enhances the potency of action. The whole day is fruitfully utilized and yet one does not get tired. Irregularity reduces output, affects the quality of work,

burdens the mind with anxiety and tires the body as well. Habit of doing everything in time averts all these possibilities. No one should find this difficult. Agriculture depends on rains. Yet regularity can be maintained even in agricultural operations barring ten or twelve days in a year. Time for meals can easily be fixed in the homes.

Regularity cannot be ensured in each and every activity. But if it is ensured in main activities, regularity in occasional activities is automatically taken care of. And it is also a common experience that regularity adds charm to the activities.

It is my experience that the early morning is the best part of the day. It is a singularly stimulating time, and should be utilized for reflection or important activities. One should, therefore, ingrain the habit of going to sleep early in the night and rising early in the morning. It provides all-round benefit—physical, mental and spiritual. People are often tempted to work in the night, but such temptation should better be avoided.

Importance of resolutions

The day should start with a pious resolution to do certain thing, it should be spent in efforts to stick to it, and the good deeds done during the day should be dedicated to God before going to bed. This routine would gradually uplift us.

Resolution should be pure and strong and foolproof. For this purpose, one should start with small resolutions and try to fulfil them. When they are fulfilled, that would give a sense of strength. That is what confidence is.

Once a resolution is made, one should stick to it. Neither should one be tempted to add to the resolution nor should one develop cold feet and abandon it. On its fulfilment, one may make a more difficult resolution.

Resolution must be pure. Its purity strengthens and uplifts the Self. In any case, one can remain firm on the resolution through soul force alone, but a pure resolution uplifts the Self, while an impure one causes its degeneration.

Once a resolution is made, it should not be abandoned if some minor defect, not related to fundamental principles, is noticed therein. That would weaken the will-power. Such defects are not as harmful as spiritual or moral defects. If the latter are noticed, the resolution should be abandoned.

A resolution should not be so easy that it would need little effort, nor should it be so difficult that it would be nearly impossible to stick to it.

Depth in study

In study, depth and seriousness are important, not the range or variety. It should be intensive, not extensive. Regular study of a particular subject, done with full concentration for a brief period is what I call deep study. It is preferable to the study of various subjects for hours on end. One may sleep for ten hours, but if that sleep is unsound or is assailed by dreams, it would not give due rest. But sleep for five or six hours can give adequate rest if it is sound and dreamless. This is true about study also.

Knowledge cannot be gained without deep study done with full absorption. Wide-ranging but cursory study is often illusive; it only saps one's strength and nothing is gained thereby. Study should result in independence and creativity, wisdom and imagination—in the blossoming of new ideas. It should lead to new discoveries, fresh inspiration and enthusiasm. Wide-ranging haphazard studies bring about exactly the opposite result.

Study should not intrude into the space for necessary

activities and duties. Otherwise, it would mean loss of the present time in our hands in the hope of having a bright future. Everyone knows how unpredictable life is. It is God's grace that He introduces some or other shortcoming in everyone. He expects us to be aware of it and be vigilant.

Two points define a line. The path of our life is also determined by two points—the point where we are at present and the point of our destination. If we can locate these two points, we perceive the direction of life. Now that path needs to be adhered to; diversion would not take us to the goal.

In short, short and measured period, regularity and consistency, full concentration, adequate room for obligatory activities and a fixed direction are the factors which ensure depth in study.

Regulation of speech

God has endowed human beings with the faculty of speech, which animals lack. They may be able to communicate with one another in some way, but they do not have the faculty of speech like the human beings. If this faculty is properly utilized, it can become an instrument for uplift.

There is difference between language and speech. Language is not God-given; speech is. Languages differ from one another, speech does not. Speech conveys what one thinks through the medium of language.

Speech should be used in a right way. One of the requirements in this regard is that truth alone must be uttered. The second requirement is that the speech should be brief. It is not that those who speak less speak truth. One may talk less to hide something. But that should not be the intent; it should be in the interest of balanced thinking.

The third consideration in this regard is that one should never speak ill of others, even if what one speaks is true; particularly behind the back of the person being so spoken of. Not only should one not speak ill of others, one should not also think ill of others. The spirit of goodwill alone should prevail. One should see only the good qualities in others.

When alleged faults of others are criticised, the very same faults, whether they actually exist in the person being criticised or not, enter the speech and pollute it. It means that we ourselves have put in our mind the dirt that was outside. This is to our own detriment.

While engaged in any work, one is required to discuss many points, and it does involve discussion of faults of others. If it is necessary, it need not be avoided, but the intent must be pure, we should have the interest and the good of others in the mind, and it should be amply clear to them; they should appreciate and accept our criticism. Then it would not hurt them. It would rather help purification of their mind. If someone is to be operated, the operation has to have consent of both the surgeon and the patient. Analysis of someone's faults should likewise have the consent of both the concerned parties. If it is not possible, it is better to keep silent.

In fact, right use of speech does involve silence also, along with truthfulness, moderation, lack of reproach and pointing out faults in others in the interest of and with the consent of others. One should realise that the faults belong to the body—they are related to physical existence—while the virtues belong to the soul. The faults are transient; they would go away with the perishing of the body. Virtues are intransient. They should be the focus of our attention, not the transient faults.

If all these aspects are taken care of well, speech will be infused with great power.

Three Requirements

For doing any work perfectly, three things are needed. The first one is that we should be able to do the work with reasonable speed. In the examinations, we have to answer some questions within the specified time. This is very important. If a military unit is supposed to reach a particular place, it is supposed to traverse the distance within the specified time. This applies to all the activities in daily life, although to differing extent. A cook may be able to cook for five persons reasonably well, but if he is taking five hours for the job, of what use is his skill? A human being is always bound by the constraints of time. He cannot disregard the time factor while doing any work.

Secondly, work should be neat and systematic. To take the example of the march of a military unit again, it has to march with military discipline, in the formation of two or three as laid down. The soldiers should walk in unison. Without systematicness, a work has little merit. Neatness and systematicness enhance the quality of work. A work performed unsystematically is not even worthy of being called work. Neatness and systematicness are not just external embellishments; they are the very heart of the work. It is not an optional quality, but a quality whose presence is imperative.

The third requirement is the knowledge. A military unit may march to its destination with the desired speed and in a disciplined manner, but what if it does not know the route and therefore does not reach the destination? March has to be well-planned. This point, in fact, is so obvious that it need not be elaborated further.

These are three essential aspects of any work. A work has to be done with full knowledge, reasonable speed and systematicness. Then alone can it be properly accomplished. For example, when can it be said that one

knows writing? When one is able to write with a reasonable speed, the handwriting is good, and is in accordance with the rules of spelling and grammar.

And this can be likened to *sat-chit-ananda* (Truth, consciousness, bliss)¹². Speed of a work is the truth in it, for only truth can stand the test of time. Knowledge of the work is like consciousness; work without knowledge is as good as dead. And is it necessary to say that beauty in the work constitutes bliss?

Fearlessness

Fearlessness is of three kinds: informed fearlessness, fearlessness based on devotion to God, and discriminative fearlessness. 'Informed' means that kind of fearlessness which results from acquainting ourselves with various kinds of fear and learning how to overcome them. This kind needs to be cultivated as much as possible. A person, who is acquainted with various kinds of snakes, knows which are poisonous ones, has mastered the art of catching snakes, knows remedies for snakebite and knows how to avoid snakes, can be said to possess such fearlessness as regards the snakes. It will, of course, be restricted to snakes only. Not everybody is likely to acquire it, but those who are likely to come across snakes should better cultivate it for its practical utility. It is beneficial spiritually too, as it inculcates a kind of boldness, which prevents a person from crossing his bounds. However, this kind of fearlessness is restricted in scope.

12. The Supreme Truth, or the *Brahman*, is said to have three aspects—*sat*, *chit* and *ananda*. *Sat* means being, that which really exists. It also means abiding, actual, right, self-existent essence. *Chit* means perception, knowledge or consciousness, while *ananda* means bliss.

The second one is based on devotion to God. It can lead to perfect fearlessness. But it can be cultivated only after persistent and focused efforts and devotion. Once it is cultivated, nothing else is needed.

The third one is discriminative fearlessness. It prevents man from undertaking any risky venture. And if fear does arise, it teaches to remain calm. Spiritual seekers should try to inculcate this kind of fearlessness in them. Everyone can achieve it. Suppose, a tiger is about to pounce on me. If my death is imminent, it cannot be avoided. But if I do not panic and keep the mind calm, there is possibility of finding a way of tackling the situation. And in case any way is not found, at least I may remember God at the last moment, if my mind is calm. It would be the greatest blessing. Discriminative fearlessness is thus beneficial from both the spiritual and the practical angle and should, therefore, be cultivated sincerely.

Awareness of Death

Death is a gift of God. When the nearest relatives, friends, experts—all are incapable of relieving our suffering, death comes to our rescue. The pain associated with death is, in reality, the pain associated with life.

The pain that diseases give is a consequence of the lack of restraint in life. And death rescues us from that pain. It is in no way related to that pain, and is unnecessarily blamed for it.

There are two other kinds of pain: one arising from the memory of past sins and the second one arising out of attachment to the near and dear ones, which makes imminent separation from them painful. How can death be considered responsible for the first kind of pain? One has to suffer the consequences of one's sins. The second one is because of attachment. If our love for the near and dear ones is genuine and we have sincere wish to serve them,

we would not go away from them on relinquishing the body; rather, we would go nearer; we would gain access to their hearts. As long as the curtain of body is there, it separates us from others. When it is removed, we can serve others by becoming one with them. Of course, this needs desire to serve. In other words, it calls for detachment.

There is one more kind of pain. But that is really related to ignorance, and not to death. It is imaginary. We are apprehensive about what would happen to us after death. But if we have faith that if something untoward happens, it would be due to our unhealthy desires and nothing else—in other words, if we have faith in God's sense of justice and fair play, this fear would not exist

Thus, there are four kinds of pain: (1) physical pain, (2) pain associated with the remembrance of our sins, (3) pain arising out of attachment to near and dear ones, and (4) apprehension about what would happen to us after death. And the remedies are respectively, (1) constant restraint, (2) righteous conduct, (3) detachment and (4) faith in God.

We should, therefore, have constant awareness of the unavoidable death, rationally analyse the phenomenon of death, and go to bed daily after rehearsing death.

Health

Reasons for ill-health

Many diseases in the villages are because of habitual lack of cleanliness, polluted water and lack of proper, balanced and nutritious diet. Intake of only cereals is not sufficient; vegetables, fruits and milk are also necessary. Polishing of rice destroys vitamin B in it, and reduces its nutritional value, besides reducing its quantity. This needs to be stopped immediately.

Freedom from addictions is also necessary for keeping good health. Things like alcohol, *beedis* and cigarettes and

opium are positively harmful from all angles. Lack of restraint and consequent wanton behaviour is giving rise to many diseases.

Besides water pollution, air pollution has also assumed alarming proportions. Plant life too has been affected by pollution.

Diseases are spreading in cities because of a sedentary lifestyle, divorced from nature and wrong habits. Nature cure can, therefore, be useful in the cities also.

Nature cure

To cure the diseases, artificial drugs are used. Naturopaths say that these artificial drugs merely suppress the disease, which erupts again after some time in some other form. To combat it, new drugs are used. This creates a vicious cycle, which chains a person permanently to diseases from which death alone sets him free. Nature cure seeks to eliminate the seed of the disease by improving the health of the body.

In ordinary illness, it is my experience that change in diet is sufficient to cure it.

The God's scheme of things is, in fact, such that He has made everyone self-reliant in all respects. Everyone can earn knowledge. Everyone has the capacity of digesting the food. He has made air and water available to all. Mud, water, clean air, sunlight—all these can be used with good effect. Body is made up of elements in the nature. What we have in the body, is present in the nature as well. We have water in the nature and blood in the body; air in the nature and breath in the body, and so on. Even minerals are present in the body. If the natural elements are ingeniously utilized, many diseases can be cured.

Nature cure should, therefore, be taught in the villages. It is not difficult to learn nature cure. It does not need much time. One only needs to develop a little

restraint and an attitude to observe keenly the effects of what we eat. It is impossible to have a hospital in every village; and even if we can have it, it would only open a new avenue for the exploitation of village. Dependence on outside doctors and drugs is certainly not worthwhile. But it is possible to teach the villagers the use of locally grown herbs.

In nature cure centres, things like hot-water bags, enema pots are kept. I suggest that every such centre should have a plot of land attached to it and patients should be asked to work on it in accordance with their physical condition. I hold that the charkha and pickaxe are also tools for nature cure.

I believe that it cannot be God's will that a human being should fall ill. He has given everything needed to human being. And he has given hunger to all. It means that God has enjoined us to labour to satisfy our hunger. But a human being does not want to labour, he wants to eat without labour; and wants to eat more than required. If we live in tune with the nature, and resolve to earn our bread only through physical labour, most of the diseases would disappear.

But, it may be asked, 'If it is so, why do the labourers fall ill?' The reason is that they have to put in excessive labour, and they do not get adequate nutrition.

Without brahmacharya, nature cure would be in vain. Movies and literature are pandering to sensuality. Licentious behaviour is rampant everywhere. In the absence of brahmacharya, many diseases would be on the rise, and it would be beyond the capacity of naturopathy to cure them, as it is primarily preventive.

Ayurveda

The science of medicine had considerably advanced in our country. I cannot claim that it was unequalled or

perfect. But this science carried out research on the plants available here; and this is what we need. But the knowledge gained so far is incomplete; we have to explore this field further.

Every village should have a herbal garden. In India, average population of a village is five hundred, and as per my calculation, one acre land is sufficient for the purpose.

It is said in ayurveda that human body is a tool for attaining spiritual liberation, and should therefore be kept pure. Secondly, if the disease is incurable, the patient's mind should be prepared for death, rather than continuing treatment unnecessarily. Thirdly, medicines should not be given the moment one becomes sick. The patient should be kept under observation and his diet should be regulated first. Pancha-karma is also prescribed, which is akin to nature cure. Change in diet in accordance with the season is also recommended.

Avoidance of certain food items, which are harmful for the particular disease, is also recommended. This factor is given so much importance that it is said that if a patient avoids these food items, he needs no treatment, and if the patient does not avoid such foods, medicines would be to little avail.

People desire good health to enable them indulge in sensual pleasures. But ayurveda says that intellect should be pure for God-realization, and body should be pure to have a pure intellect, and that is why the science of ayurveda has originated. It means that the Indian ayurvedic system is for the health of the body and purity of intellect, and aims at God-realization.

Allopathy

Allopathy has come from the West. They (the Westerners) say that body should be healthy for the

enjoyment of worldly pleasures. But such enjoyment itself gives rise to diseases, for it pays little heed to purity.

Allopathy has been benefited by modern science, for example, surgery. Diseases considered incurable hitherto can be cured by surgery. Earlier, chloroform was not available, and that put constraints on surgery. Such drugs are necessary. Contagious diseases need some special drugs to combat them. I am not opposed to them; for example, to the use of quinine to cure malaria. Some allopathic drugs, which give immediate effect in certain situations, need not be discarded. I am saying this from the angle of society; an individual, if he so chooses, can refuse to have any drug.

These days, organs are being transplanted. It shows greed for life. But there is one advantage. It would make us aware that we are separate from our organs. It is certainly beneficial to give the organ of a dying person to one who needs it.

Role of doctor

Services of medical practitioners should be free. Society should provide them enough for their subsistence. Today, doctors serve only those who pay them. This is wrong. Service of the sick is an act of compassion. Why should there be discrimination in it?

On Diet

As far as experiments about diet are concerned, I always keep four aspects in mind: (1) spirituality, (2) health, (3) swadeshi dharma,¹³ and (4) economics. If these

13. *Swadeshi* literally means that which belongs to one's own country. It has been defined by Gandhiji as 'that spirit in us which restricts us to the use and service of our immediate surroundings to the exclusion of the more remote.'

four aspects are to be analysed and their relative importance judged, I would put them in this order—the first aspect being the most important and the last one the least. But I do not subscribe to such gradation. I hold that in a truly spiritual approach, there is confluence of the other three aspects. A truly spiritual approach is also a truly swadeshi approach and a truly economic approach as well.

Purity of diet is essential to have the power of insightful understanding. That is why purity of diet has been greatly deliberated in India. Although human beings have carried out experiments in this regard all over the world, nowhere has this subject been reflected upon more deeply than in India. The conclusion that was arrived at, after carrying out several experiments in this regard, was that purity of diet leads to purity of nature or disposition. Purity of life leads to wisdom, and purity of diet is a means to achieve purity of life.

Purity of diet would purify the mind. It would also strengthen the body. It would add to our capacity to serve the society. Individuals would be contented and so would the society be. Society would be pure to the extent its members have pure diet. Virtues would gain the upper hand as passions subside. Diet reform could even lessen war-mongering in the world.

Medical science has investigated the effects of diet on health. Yogis have gone ahead; they have explored the effects of diet on human mind. That is why regulation of diet became a premier ingredient in the penance prescribed for spiritual pursuit.

The experiments in diet carried out in Gandhian ashrams had one more thing in view: quest to identify with the poor.

As far as proper diet is concerned, quantity is more

important than the kind of diet. 'How much to eat' deserves more attention than 'what to eat'.

Give up meat-eating

Primitive men perhaps survived on fruits and roots. But distorted thinking subsequently made many of them meat-eaters. The virtuous and the wise elements did not approve of this. They, therefore, laid down that if meat had to be eaten at all, meat of a sacrificed animal alone should be eaten after the performance of sacrificial rites. It was a measure meant to restrict violence. But in the course of time, sacrificial rites became a routine affair, undertaken basically for indulging in meat-eating. Lord Buddha, therefore, said, "Eat meat by all means, but do not do so at least in God's Name." This too was to curtail meat-eating. Gradually, we moved away from meat-eating. It was a great experiment that was conducted only in India. Millions abjured meat-eating. Vegetarianism has become natural to us as a result of the penance of our ancestors. We should move ahead and build on their achievement; we must not take any step backwards. Acceptance of vegetarianism is our great legacy.

We now say, '*Jai Jagat*' (Victory to the world). We seek well-being of the whole world. And the world includes animals as well. If we want peace in the world, we would have to give up eating of the animal flesh.

In fact, non-vegetarianism cannot go on in the future. Population is increasing. On an average, a non-vegetarian person needs four acres of land; if one lives on milk, one needs two acres; but a vegetarian person needs only one acre. Land to man ratio is going to fall continuously. The very survival of society—even physical survival, not to speak of any spiritual consideration—therefore depends on giving up meat-eating.

6

Language and Literature

Hindi

The culture of every country has a distinct mission. It cannot be our (India's) mission to emulate America, Russia or China. India is a unique country. Which other country has fourteen developed languages? China is a big country, but only one language is spoken there. Europe has many developed languages, but it is not a single political unit; there are a number of countries, each with a different language.

India's languages are quite developed. Tamil has literature two thousand years old. Kannad has literature 1200 years old. Europe does not have such old literature. It is India alone which carried out the great experiment of forging a single nation despite having so many languages. In this respect, India is politically much more advanced than other countries. India has her own mission. She cannot fulfil it if she clings to English.

A human being sees with two eyes. A big country like India too cannot 'see' without two languages. One is the regional language and the other is the language that is used all over the country for mutual dealings. I believe Hindi would be such language.

I do not claim that Hindi is the richest language. But it is the daughter of a rich language (Sanskrit) and sister of many rich languages. And the most important factor is that it has been the vehicle for the propagation of love and righteousness. Pilgrims moving in the country have made Hindi a vehicle for propagating love.

I have studied all the Indian languages. That has enabled me earn the love of the speakers of all the languages. But how can I speak fourteen languages? It

would not have been possible for me to spread the message of bhoodan and gramdan from Kashmir to Kanyakumari and from Assam to Kerala (throughout the length and breadth of the country) without the assistance of Hindi. Had I used Marathi, my message would not have crossed the borders of Maharashtra. With English, it would at best have reached cities and a few regions. But the message of revolution would not have reached remote villages.

Hindi, however, should be promoted in a right manner. It should not be imposed. And it need not be imposed. It would be lovingly accepted by all.

People from North India should learn a language from South India. Those from South India should, of course, learn Hindi. But should not the North Indians do something to earn the love of the South Indians? We should try to learn the languages of one another voluntarily. If South Indians learn Hindi, they would be able to propagate their ideas in the whole of India. Languages in South India are a treasure-house of great literature. The whole country can get acquainted with it through Hindi.

In my tour of Tamil Nadu, I exhorted the Tamilians, even in the bastions of anti-Hindi sentiments, to learn Hindi in their own interest. I told them that there has been a long tradition of exchange of ideas between North and South India. Once upon a time, Vaidiks, Buddhists and Jains went from north to south and propagated spiritual knowledge. In the mediaeval times Shankar, Ramanuj, Madhva etc. went from South to North India and did the same work. In the next wave, ideas of Ramakrishna Paramhansa, Gandhiji etc. went from north to south. I exhorted South Indians to perceive that their inning is now about to start; the more they are late in learning Hindi, the more would the beginning of their inning be delayed.

Nagari script

Hindi has been accepted as the language for mutual dealings. For the same reason, Nagari should be accepted as the common script. All the Indian languages should adopt Nagari. They need not discard their present scripts; these scripts can co-exist with Nagari.

It is not that Nagari is a perfect script and there is no need for any improvement in it. In fact, I am an advocate of improvements in Nagari. But I do not think that Nagari cannot or should not be adopted unless improvements are made. Let it be adopted first; improvements would follow. If we engage ourselves in improvements first, its adoption and also the improvements would be delayed ad infinitum.

Adoption of Nagari by all the Indian languages would facilitate learning of other Indian languages. It would also boost national unity and integration. In fact, Nagari would be more useful for this purpose than Hindi. If Nagari becomes the common script in India, I foresee the possibility of its adoption even outside India.

Literature:

A significant force in human affairs

Three forces contribute significantly in guiding society: science, spirituality and literature. They have considerable impact upon both individual and society. We find that only scientists and spiritual seekers have been able to change human life or have permanent impact on human life. Literature is the force that joins science and Self-knowledge. It brings about concord between them and presents it before the people in appropriate words.

We should therefore realize the potency in literature and develop the power of words. That alone would save us from taking a beating.

People often believe that politicians have a lion's share in guiding the society. They are totally mistaken. In fact, contribution of the politicians in this regard is next to nothing. Science is one of the forces that shape the life. Take, for instance, this loudspeaker. It is because of loudspeaker that thousands can hear my talk. Otherwise, they would have to remain content with merely seeing me. This loudspeaker brings about a change not only in the material world, but also in the minds. Printing is another instance of the change brought about by science in the human life.

Spirituality is another force which radically shapes human life. Great spiritual figures like Gautam Buddha, Jesus Christ, Prophet Mohammed, Jnanadeva, Tulsidas or Manikkavachakar appeared on the scene from time to time and brought about great changes in human life.

So have great writers like Valmiki, Vyasa, Shakespeare, Homer, Shankaracharya or Rabindranath. They gave the world what it needed at a particular juncture. All the great revolutions in the world have occurred because of visionary thinkers and writers.

Science brings about change in the material world. It cannot directly affect the mind. Words can. They provide a bridge to join science and spirituality. In the process, they illuminate both.

Qualities of a writer

The ideas, the thoughts that are revealed through deep meditation and direct experience need to be expressed in appropriate words that would make them understandable and acceptable. Every word has to be judiciously selected; otherwise, it would obfuscate rather than clarify the idea. The word should neither express less than what is intended to be conveyed nor more nor what is different or opposite in meaning. Care has to be taken

to avoid these risks and to express the idea in a proper manner. This calls for a particular skill. Writers are expected to possess this skill—the skill to express ideas in appropriate, balanced, agreeable and adroit way. It needs love for all, objectivity, lack of passions in speech and lack of ego.

A writer needs to have a vision. He should be able to guide others. He should know the right path, should explore it if need be, and show it to the people. He should perceive what others fail to perceive—he needs to have a 'third eye' for this purpose.

It is said about Prophet Mohammed that he would sweat profusely when in trance he received divine messages, so much so that people around him would be alarmed. The pain that the divine message induces in the human heart is indeed greater than the labour pains. A person having experience of such pain feels bewildered and wants to get out of that state. The vision that such a state produces takes the form of a piece of literature, which people appreciate. They have no inkling of what the writer had gone through.

A writer can never be sectarian if his writings are to have lasting value. He should possess the spirit of empathy for the whole universe. He should identify with his subject. When sage Valmiki saw the curlew bird hurt by an arrow, the cruelty struck him deeply and the rage in his breast found expression in the form of a couplet.¹⁴

A writer's role differs from that of ordinary folk and the Self-realised soul. People at large are victim of passions; passions lead them astray. A spiritually elevated person is untouched by them and is a neutral observer.

14. That couplet, which is the first one in Valmiki's Ramayana, is also considered the first verse in Sanskrit literature.

Peculiarity of a writer is that he experiences the passions and sentiments like the ordinary folk, and yet remains detached enough to keep intact the capacity of expressing them dispassionately. He is interested in and has sympathies directed towards the people, and yet is neutral. Therein lies his skill.

Qualities of literature

Sanskrit word for literature is 'sahitya'. The word itself conveys that literature is not something absolute and independent of anything. It exists relative to something; it accompanies something (*sahit*). What is it that it should accompany? A firm commitment to life. Literature should identify itself with the commitment to life. Life and literature cannot exist without each other. Literature should also walk hand-in-hand with the truth. Truth is the foundation of human life.

The Bhagavata says, literature is that which can wash off the sins of people. What a high ideal!

Literature should be in tune with the community's loftier aspirations. It should give voice to the nation's mind.

I find sky as the best metaphor for literature. It is as extensive as the sky; it gives space and provides momentum to everything.

Literature should never tire anyone. One is never tired of hearing melodious music. If literature fails in this, it has clearly not lived up to expectations.

Literature should give new insights every time you read it. It should reveal new meanings. Its words should go on developing and acquiring new meanings with time.

Brevity is another hallmark of good literature. It should use as few words as possible. It should never be aggressive. It should convey what it wants to in an

indirect and allusive manner. It is for the readers to derive any lesson from it. True literature is that which is capable of providing such a lesson; and even if a reader does not derive any lesson from it, he still finds it interesting and absorbing. I, therefore, equate literature with nonviolence. People may find it far-fetched. But even writers have vouched that good literature is necessarily suggestive and evocative. It should not try to impress something in a crude and blatant manner. It should affect the readers gently and indirectly.

Purpose of literature

I have thought much about the purpose of literature. I would like to present my conclusion in the form of an aphorism. It is an old one, but I interpret it in a different way. The aphorism is: काव्यं यशसेऽर्थकृते व्यवहारविदे शिवेतरक्षये. It is about poetry, but is applicable to all kinds of literature.

काव्यं यशसे : Poetry should be for glory. For whose glory? For the glory of God. Poetry should sing the glory of God, that is, Truth. In other words, it should uphold the maxim that Truth is always victorious in the end, and convince the people about it.

अर्थकृते : Poetry should interpret life. Human life differs from animal life is so far as it is marked with reason and knowledge. It is the function of literature to explain the import and purport of every incident, every action in life.

व्यवहारविदे : Thirdly, it should guide our conduct and dealings and systematize them. It should guide us as regards our dealings with the parents, the spouse, the children, the friends and the society at large. In this sense, literature covers sociology, economics and religion to a large extent. It should also tell us what we should give to the world and what we should accept.

शिवेतरक्षये : Fourthly, it should have a cleansing, purifying effect on people. This is the most important

purpose of literature. Without it, the other three purposes cannot be understood.

Prakash, not prachar

A writer once asked me how he could help the Bhoodan movement. But I would never ask the writers to write on Bhoodan; for it would be stupid and audacious on my part—audacious because writers know their business well, and stupid because no writer writes at anyone else's bidding. What I expect from writers is that they should observe the Bhoodan work objectively.

I do not want what is called *prachar*—propaganda or publicity; I want *prakash*—I want due light to be shed on my work. '*Prakash*' is an Indian word, while English words 'propaganda' and 'publicity' are shallow and superficial in sense. I do not want exaggeration implied in them. But I do want that the thought behind my work should become a subject of serious study, reflection and illumination.

I do not want 'broadcast'; I want 'deep-cast'.

7

Propagation of views

These days, there are considerable differences of opinion among us. There is nothing wrong in having differences of opinion. But we must distinguish between differences of opinion and disunion of hearts. An opinion is what our mind dictates independently. But the mind is like the British monarch. Has he independent views? Parliament makes resolutions and sends them for formal approval of the monarch. He has to put his signature on them. The condition of our mind is similar. Sense organs decide and the mind has to fall in line. The only difference is that mind is instinctively rational and therefore make rationalisations in favour of the decisions. It advances arguments in their favour. It is not otherwise satisfied. Beyond that, using logical reasoning against the dictates of sense organs is perhaps outside its authority.

It has been laid down that spiritual seekers should reason in tune with the Vedas. Likewise, the mind is as if rule-bound to advance arguments in tune with the dictates of sense organs. An opinion so arrived at is no real opinion; it is a kind of self-deception. Organs are averse to rising early, so the mind argues, 'It is not good to rise early, for there would not then be full alertness during the day. It is against the divine scheme; had it not been so, God would have given light in the early hours.' And we take it as our opinion. We uphold independence of opinions for all individuals. But we have not really understood what an independent opinion means. An independent opinion is that which the mind arrives at without being influenced by the sense organs. An opinion is not what comes to the mind, but what the mind brings. If one realize this, most of the differences would fall off of their own accord.

It is absolutely right to propagate what we feel to be right, provided we have restrained our sense organs beforehand. But the proper way to propagate it is to shape our conduct in accordance with it. To seek to propagate something through speech alone is illusory. This illusion is quite widespread among us. If our opinion were right, it would be automatically propagated when we put it in practice. We should have faith in truth. Truth has inherent power to propagate itself. It is self-luminous like the sun. Just as the sun cannot be covered, truth too cannot be covered. Attempt to propagate something without practising it is futile. It rather spreads untruth and violence.

Propagation has its limits. The sun can spread its rays far and wide. But it too does not transgress limits. If someone is sleeping, the sun waits at his door. It does not come in by pushing the door. But once the door is opened, it immediately enters the room. This is how something should be propagated.

Even if our opinions are true, they must be propagated in a natural manner. To put them in practice silently is the right way of propagation. Violence makes its entry the moment that silence is broken. And the entry of violence inevitably means sacrifice of truth. Truth is extinguished by violence just as water extinguishes fire. And an attempt to propagate an opinion without putting it in practice is nothing but naked violence. Impatience for propagation is also a kind of violence. It also shows ignorance and lack of faith. And why not call it hypocrisy too? Children sow a seed and when it germinates, try to pull out the sapling to make it grow rapidly. Is not the impatience to spread our thoughts similar?

An opinion is what a mind feels after restraining the sense organs, and practice is the best way to propagate it—once these two fundamental principles are accepted, everything becomes clear. One need not altogether rule

out utterance of opinions; it may accompany action to a little extent. But the temptation to refute others' views must be avoided. It is usually believed that refutation of what others say is an essential part of propagation of our views. But this is not true. Such refutation does not prove that what we say is right. In fact, lighting a lamp and dispelling darkness are not two different jobs. Similarly, presentation of our opinion is sufficient; there is then no need for refutation of opposite views. In fact, when a particular opinion is vehemently refuted, that betrays subtle attraction for that opinion.

At times, the flaws in the opinions of others may have to be pointed out while presenting our opinions. But that should not take the form of criticising the holder of those opinions personally. While pointing out that someone's point of view lacks substance, the holder of that view need not be dragged into picture. A man's opinion may be wrong; the man himself is pure. His opinions are often shaped by external circumstances. We should be able to appreciate the essence of a man even when we rebut his opinion that we perceive to be wrong. We often find that our opinions too change with the time. If we do not like any of our opinions that we held in the past, we discard it and may even refute it. But what would the manner of and spirit behind such refutation be? We should refute others' opinions with the same spirit and in the same manner—as if we are refuting our own old opinion. And we must realize that our present opinion too is subject to change.

A man does not really know his true opinions. There are layers of opinions, one over the other, on his mind. On removal of those layers, one would find the mind at the core pure and straightforward.

And let it also be kept in mind that the whole truth cannot be contained in my opinion alone. A part of truth

lies with others as well. This conviction is the foundation of satyagraha, and this is what defines the boundaries of satyagraha. No human being, no community, no institution is totally devoid of truth, totally bereft of divinity. That is why satyagraha can win over every human being, every community, every institution. We should, therefore, use nonviolent means while resisting them. This defines the boundary of satyagraha. In short, we should distinguish between the opinion or the act and the doer. That is the first and foremost principle of satyagraha.

(An article written in 1925)

8

History and Mythology

On History

The present lies hidden somewhere between the eternal past and the future whose end is not in sight. In no time, it merges into the past. It is, therefore, the duty of human beings to use it in action, rather than thinking about it. It is the specific task of history to impress on human beings the swiftness of time, ephemerality of man's earthly existence and the immortality of soul. One who has ingrained this lesson on one's mind and utilizes the present can truly be said to have understood what history is.

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A mother cuddles her child and feeds him lovingly. It does not make news. But a murder or a dacoity instantly becomes news and is recorded in history. A human being does not record what reflects humanity in history. It is an attack on humanity that is recorded. History cannot, therefore, be a guide to understand the human psyche. It is because of this that history has been reduced to a chronicle of violent incidents.

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History should really record the evolution of human values. It should tell how the content of human conscience has developed over time. This would make the conscience a guide for man.

There was a time when hands of thieves used to be severed as a deterrent punishment. This punishment has been prescribed in Hindu scriptures and in the Quran as well. When we thus punish a thief, we make his family supportless and vulnerable and put its burden on the

society. To put a thief in jail is also a wrong practice. He should rather be educated and provided with some means of livelihood, so that he is not driven to steal to provide for his family. Society is as much to blame for a theft as a thief. Modern psychology has given us this awareness.

The practice of hanging a murderer is still in vogue, but it is being challenged. The matter is under active reconsideration.

The Mahabharata is considered a great religious scripture. It notes the history of human life better than anything else. There is an incident in it that the Pandavas play *dyoot*, a gambling game, and stake and lose themselves. Today, rightness of Pandavas' action would be questioned. But in those times, it was considered obligatory to accept an invitation to play this game. The Pandavas played, staked themselves and lost. They then staked their wife, Draupadi and lost her too. She asked whether the Pandavas, who had already lost themselves, continued to have right over their wife, but respected wise old men like Bhishma, Drona and Vidur could not answer; they remained tongue-tied. Today, we would not find the question perplexing. But it was so in those times even for the wise. For, it is convention that dictates the conduct of life and is the basis of law.

Our conscience has now advanced. Now aggression on another nation is not considered legitimate; only defence is so considered. Conscience thus goes on advancing in many respects. In future, war for defence may also be disapproved. It is the job of history to tell about individuals who have helped this process, who have shaped human conscience. There could be four types of such individuals: (1) ideal rulers, like Shivaji, (2) saints, (3) poets and authors and (4) scientists. They have lasting impact on human life.

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One fact strikes when we look at the past. Around two to three thousand years ago, religions were founded all over the world. Buddha, Mahavir, Confucius, Lao Tzu, Zarathustra—all belong to a period of about five hundred years. They did not know one another. But all of them were inspired to found a religion. Then came the era of saints, an era when devotion acquired prominence everywhere. It was followed by the era of nationalism. Independence and unity of nations became the major concern. There were wars of Independence everywhere.

Now the age of global unity is approaching. It demands that narrow parochial prides—pride of religion, of caste, of language—should be forsaken. The world will become a single nation and present nations will become its provinces and so on, with the village becoming a single family. It is all a question of scale.

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सत्याचें शोधन सर्वस्व-नाशन। हे समीकरण भक्तांसाठी ॥
हरिश्चंद्रकथा जी लोकविश्रुत। सांगे हा सिद्धांत उद्घोषून॥
हरिश्चंद्र व्यक्ति प्रागैतिहासिक। कथा पौराणिक सांकेतिक ॥
इतिहास सांगे वृत्त झालें गेलें। पुराण शाश्वत सार बोले ॥
देह इतिहास आत्मा तो पुराण। नित्य सनातन विन्या म्हणे॥

(For the devotees, pursuit of truth means total sacrifice. The famous story of Harishchandra¹⁵ loudly proclaims this principle. The story belongs to prehistoric times; it is a symbolic mythological story. History tells what has happened in the past. Mythology presents the eternal essence therein. History is like the physical body; mythology is like the eternal soul.)

15. King Harishchandra gifted his kingdom to sage Vishwamitra because of a promise given to him in dream and became a destitute and had to suffer untold miseries, which he endured because of his commitment to truth.

History only notes the happenings. Mythology takes up the facts therein and uses them to spell out eternal truths. It is, therefore, more meaningful than history. Whether the individuals depicted in mythological stories actually existed or not matters little; the qualities they embody are important. They can inculcate moral virtues in us. The mythological incidents may be true or false; for me, they represent true history if they have given new direction to human life.

To the Critics of Ramayana

(From the talk at Morappur in Tamil Nadu on 1 August 1956. It is on the background of anti-Rama sentiments in the region, fuelled by the Dravid movement.)

There are, as far as I know, two major points in the criticism of Rama, the hero of Ramayana. One is that he was a North Indian who invaded South India, and Ramayana is the story of conquest and subjugation of South India. The second objection is that he was not as ideal as he is made out to be; his life had many blemishes.

The first point of criticism is rather serious. This was conceived by Western historians. So long as they had not presented history in such a perspective, it was beyond the imagination of Indians. Intentionally or unintentionally, they have created many differences among us through their presentation and interpretation of history. They have never understood correctly that this subcontinent has been from time immemorial an 'ocean of humanity', which has welcomed and made an attempt to assimilate various racial groups which had come in waves.

In my childhood, I would often hear the story of Rama in my home. There was hardly a day when I did not hear some portion of Ramayana. I never imagined that the story was historically true. I never imagined that

a person named Ravana actually existed. I have travelled through the length and breadth of India, but I have never come across a person with ten heads, like Ravana. I have not even seen a person with two heads! No book of history depicts a person with ten heads. We must realize that no book, which depicts a man with ten heads, can have historical authenticity. It has been described that the Vanaras, Rama's army men, would enter Kumbhakarna's body through one of his nostrils and come out through another nostril. I have gone through a number of books on history, but nowhere have I come across such things in them.

So, I realized, and I was also told in my childhood, that Ramayana is not a book of history. It is an allegory depicting the eternal war between gods and demons—between good and evil—being waged in our hearts. Ravana represents *rajas*, Kumbhakarna *tamas* and Bibhishana *sattva*. Our hearts would be purified only when the ten-headed demon within them is eliminated. I have heard it since my childhood that by taking the Name of Rama and hearing His story, an individual gets strength to fight the demon within the heart. I want to tell you that I have not come across a single man in North India who interprets Ramayana as the story of the aggression on South by North India. It is an allegory, a mythological tale which we have been hearing and reading for the purification of our hearts and for arousal of loving devotion for the Lord therein.

Scholars and saints in the South India have also interpreted Ramayana in the same way. Had Kamban believed that it was the history of invasion of North Indians on South India, would he have written Ramayana? But he has written Ramayana, looking to Rama as a manifestation of God. There is hardly any other book in Tamil which can equal Kamban's Ramayana. If one has a little knowledge of psychology,

one can realize that such a great work cannot be written if it is taken as a story of conquest. Slaves do indulge in servility and flattery of their conquerors, but one cannot count Kamban among them.

Just as Kamban's Ramayana is the greatest work in Tamil, Ezhuthachan's Ramayana is considered the greatest work in Malayalam. It is read in every home in Kerala. Had Ramayana been a story of conquest of South India, would South Indians saints have glorified it?

Ramayana receives the same respect, it is interpreted in the same way in Karnataka and Andhra.

I have not come across any other book, which can help more in the purification of heart. I would go to the length of saying that as far as Hindu dharma is concerned, even the Gita takes the second place. The Gita is like butter, whereas Ramayana is like pure milk. Even a child can digest milk, but not all can digest butter. Therefore, even the Gita cannot do the work of purification of hearts to the extent Ramayana has done, and is doing. You will understand from this how the whole India looks upon the Ramayana.

Gandhiji used to say that he had found no other sacred book, which can develop devotion, the love of God, more than the Ramayana by Tulsidas. Rama that it depicts is the Rama that abides in every heart as the Self, which liberates the heart from Ravana. The heart is then freed from attachment and hatred of all kinds and is filled with pure devotion. Ramayana creates such a divine atmosphere. India has been enslaved many a time in her long history, but it could not be destroyed. Had India lost Ramayana, it would have perished. It is because of Ramayana that it is holding her head high. Those who are entertaining ideas propounded by the Western historians should, therefore, discard them.

The second objection is that Rama's life was not ideal; he is not without blemish. But you can write Ramayana, where Rama does not have the faults Rama of ancient epics had. After all, it is not a book of history. Had it been history, you would have been required to stick to the facts. But you can use your imagination and depict Rama as you want. We cannot do this about Shivaji, because he is a historical character. Those who wrote Ramayana had written as they wanted. Tulsidas' Ramayana differs from that of Valmiki. There are many differences. The story of the killing of Shoodrak is there in Valmiki's Ramayana, but not in Tulsidas'. In Tulsi-Ramayana, Rama does not banish Sita. Tulsidas' Rama does not, and cannot banish Sita and send her to a forest, as Sita, for Tulsidas, is a part of Rama. Tulsidas does not even describe the incident of Rama's going to heaven. Tulsi-Ramayana creates the faith that Rama is always with us. The moment a sacred thought arises in our minds, Rama is born there; and where there is Rama, Sita—the personification of devotion to him—is invariably there. In Tulsi-Ramayana, Ravana does not abduct Sita; he takes away her fictitious image, while she has been hidden in fire. Such is the world of Tulsidas' imagination.

As far as the incident in which Rama deserts Sita is concerned, we have to take into account the fact that sometimes a human being is faced with a moral dilemma, that is, he is faced with two conflicting duties, and to whom precedence should be given becomes a vexatious problem. Rama faced such a dilemma: whether to discharge the duty of a king or the duty of a husband? To fulfil one duty meant abandoning another. Whatever choice he might have made, it would have invited criticism and he would have incurred sin. He thought that Sita trusted him implicitly and there was no likelihood of her misunderstanding him; about the subjects, he was not so sure. So he asked Laxman to take Sita to the forest and

leave her near a sage's ashram (where she would be cared for). Rama was sure that Sita would never accuse him of harshness, even though the whole world might so accuse him.

What I want to say is that we are well within our rights to describe Rama's life as an ideal one. We can make any number of changes in it. Such liberty cannot be taken about historical personages. India's history starts from Lord Buddha. It is not that Rama and Krishna had never existed; they might have, but Rama and Krishna that the Ramayana and the Bhagavata depict are the forms of the Supreme. If Rama is looked upon as a human being, as depicted by Valmiki, one is fully entitled to criticize him. I also used to criticize Rama in my childhood. We used to discuss whether Rama was fair to Vali, whether he was right in banishing Sita etc. Rama as a human being is not perfect; he had to be imperfect, as Ravana had obtained a boon that no god could defeat him. Had Rama been perfect, he would have been a god and, therefore, could not have been able to kill Ravana. God had to descend as a human being for the purpose. And a human being is bound to have some failings, just as any form is invariably accompanied with its shadow. Human being has both virtues and faults. We have to appreciate the virtues and tolerate the faults. Gandhiji admitted that sometimes he made 'Himalayan blunders'. There is nothing surprising in this, as he performed Himalayan tasks also. So his mistakes also were bound to be great. If we find any failings in the life of Rama, we should not pay attention to them and should emulate his good qualities only.

Bhagavata is also read in every home. Every mother tells her children the stories of Krishna stealing butter. I have not seen any other book glorifying stealing. But will the mother allow her child to steal in her home? The story of Krishna is not for teaching stealing. No child

takes from it the lesson that one should steal. He knows that it is a mythological story, depicting the divine play.

Moreover, Hindu dharma allows you not to consider Rama perfect. If you do not like the Ramayana, do not read it; there are other books, which you may read. This is a great characteristic of Hindu dharma, which is not to be found in any other religion. There are good things in all the religions, and they should be accepted. But no Christian can ever say that if you do not like Bible, put it aside and read another book. He would say that if you do not like Bible, you are not a Christian. Hindu dharma, on the other hand, is linked neither to Rama nor to Krishna nor to any other form of God; I would even say that even the concept of God is not essential to it.

When we are followers of such a religion, we need not hate anyone. Let us leave aside what we do not like and accept what we like. Should one read Ramayana? Well, one need not read anything at all! A human being needs to strive for purification of heart and Self-realization. That is true religion. If a book helps in this regard, read it. Books are for us; we are not for books—this is the stand of Hindu dharma. There is absolutely no reason for us to fight in this regard. If we exploit such things to exacerbate differences, the country will be weakened.

**Reflections
on the Ramanama**

Introduction

I came across, by chance, the collection of Gandhiji's thoughts on the Rama-nama (the Name of Lord Rama), when I genuinely needed it. The monthly 'Sarvodaya'¹⁶ receives many books for review. The book 'Rama-nama' was one of them. I rarely find time to glance through those books, but I got absorbed in reflecting upon this one.

It was as if Gandhiji had given his message for me in the form of this book. I have been on the tour of the country for a couple of years. I have spent thirty years in different kinds of constructive work. I had to reflect upon a lot of things. I was explaining the inferences drawn from them to the people. However, as I was not much used to such tours, irregularities (in diet etc.) occurred and the stomach pain, which had started during my incarceration, raised its head again. Perhaps, God gave me an opportunity to have recourse to nature cure and Ramanama. Perhaps the compassionate Lord, who is always with His devotee, desired to test the patience of the devotee. Teachers teach, and then test how far their teaching has been assimilated by the pupils. I thought I was facing a similar test. I humbly discontinued my tour and started introspection.

During this period, I had put aside the varied other activities I was engaged in, as that was supposed to be a period of rest. Yet I continued to edit 'Sarvodaya'. I had also to complete the dictionary of Gitai.¹⁷ I was devoting some time to this work. These exceptions apart, I had mostly suspended the rest of my activities. At that time, I

16. The Hindi monthly of which Vinoba was the editor at that time.

17. Translation of the Gita in Marathi verse by Vinoba.

happened to lay my hands on the collection of Gandhiji's thoughts on Ramanama, compiled by Bharatan Kumarappa. I thought that the god of health had sent me a divine herb to cure my disease, and I started taking this medicine with faith.

I reflected on these thoughts to digest them and then presented my reflections through an article in the 'Sarvodaya' (December 1949). I normally write in Marathi, for that is the language I know. But I wrote this article in Hindi, as the original book that I had before me was in Hindi, and my reflections were consequently in Hindi. The same is now being published in the form of a book; and this is the preface of that book.

Many expressed their happiness after reading this article. Many wrote that this article had given a new direction to their life. One of the readers wrote, "I have always been reading Gandhiji's thoughts on Ramanama, but they had not been imprinted on my heart. Your article has dissolved every trace of doubt." Clearly, this is just a eulogy of the article. Yet the experience of this reader is not beyond my imagination. We find that man derives more benefit from the clouds, which receive sustenance from the sea, than from the sea itself. The case is similar. Digestive organs of some people cannot digest nourishing food directly, unless it is made digestible before eating.

I have made the faith in the remembrance of the Lord's Name a settled conviction. It has been reinforced by actual experience. I have presented it in the same manner to the readers through this article. It has given me an opportunity to articulate my reflections and experience, and I too have been benefited by it. Tulsidas, it is said, wrote 'Hanuman-bahuk' while ill, and that helped cure his disease. Perhaps it is not apt to cite such a lofty example, but I must say that this article has verily proved to be 'Hanuman-bahuk' for me.

To Begin With

Bharatan Kumarappa has compiled in a book Gandhiji's thoughts on Ramanama, expressed from time to time, and Navajivan Publishing House has published it. It is a collection of some articles, lectures and letters. An annexure gives an anecdote about how thoroughly Gandhiji's life was permeated with Ramanama.

The book gives everything in a nutshell. Like Gandhiji's 'Mangal Prabhat' (From Yervada Mandir), which describes the vows prescribed by him, it too is of lasting value. Here I seek to reflect on it a bit.

Extolment of the Name

All the religions have extolled the Names of the Lord. Although every religion has its own world-view, there is no difference in approach or thinking as far as this aspect is concerned. All the religions have thought of different Names of the Lord in accordance with His different attributes and have prescribed chanting of one or more of those Names as per one's interests and needs; and all saints have reinforced this tradition through their practice. Whether God is believed to have a form or to be formless is immaterial here. Nanak's 'Japuji' and Jnanadeva's 'Haripath' belong to two different religious denominations, but as far as the singing of the Lord's Names is concerned, there is no difference between the two. The Bhagavata sings the auspicious Names of the Lord and the Quran tells the beads of the rosary of Asma Ul Husna: the only difference is that the former is in Sanskrit and the latter is in Arabic.

Every Indian language abounds in devotional literature. No language lags behind any other in this respect. Tulsidas, Chaitanya, Tukaram, Narasinha Mehta and Nammalwar write in different languages, but it appears that they are translating one another. Tulsidas'

'Ramayana' ascribes superiority to the Name over even Lord Rama. Tulsidas has even written a small and sweet tract titled 'Namayan', which compares the two. Gandhiji has derived inspiration from it, experienced the truth in it and has revealed it to us.

The first utterance expressing the perception of the spiritual power in the Lord's Name appears in the Vedas. The word 'Naam' appears in the Rig-Veda about a hundred times. But the Upanishads have declared that the Name of the Lord is the essence of all the Vedas: सर्वे वेदा यत् पदं आमनन्ति — 'All the Vedas thoroughly contemplate the Lord's Name alone'. It is for this reason that the Vedas have been valled आम्नाय (*amnaaya*), that is, those which comprehensively contemplate the Lord's Names.

The saints have reinforced this faith. Tukaram, the Vaishnava saint, asserts:

वेद अनंत बोलिला, अर्थ इतुकाचि साधिला ।
विठोबासी शरण जावें, निज-निष्ठा नाम गावें ।

—"Although the Vedas have talked about a lot of things, surrender to Lord Vitthal and singing of His Name with devotion are the essence of all that." Tukaram had no knowledge of Sanskrit, yet he knew the essence of the Vedas. He proclaims confidently:

वेदाचा तो अर्थ आम्हांसीच ठावा
येरांनी वाहावा भार माथां ।

—"We alone know the import of the Vedas; others are only carrying their load on their heads!"

What the Vaishnava saint Tukaram knew was known to Jnana-sambandar, the towering Shaiva saint:

वेद नान्गिनुम् मेय पोरुळावदु
नाद-नामम् नमः शिवाय

—"If there is any essential truth in the four Vedas, it is the Name of Lord Shiva."

It is not something that others should attest to, nor is it a matter of faith alone. The Vedas themselves have to say this about them:

ऋचो अक्षरे परमे व्योमन् - - -
यस् तत् न वेद किम् ऋचा करिष्यति ।

—“All the verses, that is, mantras in the Vedas are contained in a single syllable—in the Name of the Lord, who is hidden in the great sky of the heart. What use are the mantras to him who does not know the Lord?” That syllable is ॐ (om). It represents the Lord, immanent in all.

Gandhiji has been repeatedly asked who his Rama is. And he has pointed towards this endearing Rama, who is immanent in all in the form of the Self. People ask, “Is he the son of Dashrath?” I reply, “He is one whose name Dasharath gave to his son.” He is the son of the universe, and therefore the son of Dashrath as well. He has taken the form of the universe and yet has transcended it.

तुका म्हणे जें जें बोला। तें तें साजे या विठ्ठला—Tukaram says, “Whatever words you may use to describe the Lord, they are befitting to Him.”

Once Tukaram got angry with the Lord. So he began to abuse Him, “You are a donkey, a dog, a beast of burden!” Does the Lord have only those Names that appear in the Vishnusahasranam, and not these? In the Vishnusahasranam, the very first Name of Lord Vishnu is not Vishnu, but ‘vishvam’ (universe). The whole universe is but the Name of the Lord. Let those who can understand this, realize it.

In the Vedas, several verses celebrate the beautiful Names of the Lord. But the following one is particularly well known among the devotees:

मर्ता अमर्त्यस्य ते भूरि नाम मनामहे ।
विप्रासो जातवेदसः ॥

—“O Lord! We are subject to death; You are immortality itself. We are desirous of knowledge; You are the knower as well as full of knowledge. We are small; we contemplate Your great Name.” In the verse, the word equivalent to ‘small’ should be assumed to be there, in contrast to great (भूरि). We observe that here the contemplation of the Name has been mentioned, not mere utterance. And this is what Gandhiji insistently repeats: “*Ramanama is to be taken from the bottom of the heart; it should not merely be mouthed. It is not just an external act; it is a means of inner purification.*”

In the verse quoted above, the famous three-fold Upanishadic prayer is hidden:

असतो मा सद् गमय ।
तमसो मा ज्योतिर् गमय ।
मृत्योर् मा अमृतं गमय ॥

(Lead us from untruth to truth, from darkness to light, from death to immortality.)

What is untrue is also narrow and small; what is true is what this mantra calls भूरि. The other two prayers are self-explanatory.

Meaning of ‘naam’

Before proceeding further, let us first have a look at the literal meaning of ‘naam’. The word has been derived from the root ‘nam’ (‘नम्’) from which the words *namra* (नम्र) (humble) and *namaskar* (नमस्कार) (respectful salutation) have also been derived. Naam would take the devotee from untruth to truth; but, first of all, it would make him humble. Humility is an essential precondition for the search for truth. Therefore, all the scientists are humble. Humility is essential for inner purification; therefore, all the spiritual seekers are humble. We invariably recollect here Gandhiji’s wonderful prayer, ‘O the Lord of humility, give us Your humility.’ It is worth recollecting not only

during the morning prayer, but also throughout the day. Kishorlalbhai (Mashruwala), a worshipper of humility, has written, "This term (the Lord of humility) that Gandhiji has used for God is unprecedented in religious literature. He did not call God the Lord of fourteen worlds or the resident of paradise; he called Him the Lord of humility, which denotes the height of the absence of the sense of separate individuality, the ideal of reducing oneself to a cipher." What Kishorlalbhai says is broadly true, but when we have a look into the literal meaning, the import of the word 'naam' and also the meaning derived from experience, how could we call the epithet used by Gandhiji as unprecedented?

Surely, those conversant with different streams in the literature about the glory of 'naam' would not accept that it is unprecedented. That Gandhiji has used this epithet is certainly remarkable, but the epithet is a legacy of earlier devotees. It has been said in an Upanishad: तत् नम इति उपासीत, नम्यन्ते अस्मै कामाः—"He should be worshipped in the form of humility. To him who would worship in this way, all the desires would have to submit." In other words, he would be completely free of desires.

The following statement also appears in the Veda as regards the Lord being the epitome of humility:

नम इत् उग्रं नम आ विवासे नमो दाधार पृथिवीं उत द्याम् ।

—"Humility is indeed a lofty quality. I worship humility. Humility supports both the earth and the heaven." The last part of the sentence makes it clear that humility is a term for the Lord. Gandhiji, while describing the humility of the Lord, has called Him 'resident of the dilapidated hut of a wretched sweeper'. The Veda says, "No one can avoid being friends with You; for You become a cow for one who wants a cow and a horse for one who wants a horse: गौः असि गव्यते, अश्वो अश्वायते भव।"

Who can indeed avoid being friends with one who is so humble and ever ready to yield to devotion? In short, the first and the foremost expectation from the contemplation of the Lord's Names is, and should be, the inculcation of humility. This is what the word 'naam' itself conveys.

Three kinds of freedom

Now we will enter into the inside of the book. On reading this book, I was reminded of Shankaracharya's commentary on the Vishnusahasranam (Thousand Names of Lord Vishnu). In that commentary, meaning of every Name has been given and different aspects of the meaning have been elaborated. Gandhiji has explained many aspects of the Ramanama in this book in the language intelligible to the modern readers. All these are hidden in the Shankaracharya's commentary. I use the word 'hidden' because the writing style there is aphoristic, so that reflection is needed to grasp the import fully. This is true about Shankaracharya's commentary as well. There is an interesting story about that commentary. It is said to be Shankaracharya's first work. He used to write down reflections on one scriptural saying every day on a slate, but goddess Saraswati would erase it. Finally, he started writing on the Vishnusahasranam, which Saraswati did not erase. I do not know which of human literature would the Time Spirit erase. Perhaps it would erase all of it. But undoubtedly, the Lord's Name would never be erased.

While analyzing the book, one finds in it three kinds of freedom: freedom from fear, freedom from passions and freedom from diseases.

(1) Freedom from fear:

When Gandhiji found the Hindus in Bengal extremely frightened (in 1946), he presented Ramanama as the remedy. This is what the book notes:

He told them, *"The greatest help you can give me is to banish fear from your hearts." And what was the talisman that could do that for them? It was the unfailing mantra of Ramanama. "You may say that you do not believe in Him. You do not know that but for His will you could not draw a single breath. He resides in the heart of the pure always. If you walk in fear of that Name, you need fear no man on earth." Why should they be afraid of the cry of 'Allaho Akbar'? The Allah of Islam was the protector of innocence. Who could dishonour their wives or daughters, if they had faith in God? He, therefore, expected them to cease to be afraid of Mussulmans. If they believed in Ramanama they must not think of leaving East Bengal. They must live where they were born and brought up and die if necessary, defending their honour as brave men and women. "To run away from danger, instead of facing it, is to deny one's faith in man and God and even one's own self. It were better for one to drown oneself than to live to declare such bankruptcy of faith."*

No further elaboration is necessary. If Gandhiji has done any public work in his life, it is that of freeing the people from fear. In the ashram vows, he included fearlessness as a separate vow. Human life becomes worthless in the absence of fearlessness. There is nothing new in this point. We have always held that the aim of the social and political order is the cultivation of *'abhaya'* (fearlessness). These days, the phrase *'law and order'* is in vogue. But the word prevalent in India was *'abhaya'* (fearlessness).

Whenever Gandhiji found himself incapable of inculcating fearlessness in the people, he initiated singing of Ramadhun: *'Raghupati Raghava Rajaram'*. But the point to be pondered over is that why should *'Allaho Akbar'* and *'Har Har Mahadev'*, the two proclamations which are as if translations of each other and both of which sing the glory of Allah—that is, God—induce fear instead of dispelling fear?

Killing the brethren with the Lord's Name on the lips had been the order of the day for so long that some people have become sick of the Lord's Name. They say, *"We have nothing to do with the Lord or His Name. Love is sufficient for us."* I tell them not to get disheartened. Ramanama is the weapon of those who want to have love in their hearts. It is not the weapon of those who hate other human beings. You should not surrender your weapon to your enemies. People misuse the word *'dispassion'*, so we say that we have nothing to do with dispassion. People make a travesty of renunciation, so we begin hating the word *'renunciation'*. We sense hypocrisy in people's devotion, so we begin hating devotion. In this way, we go on surrendering sacred words and effective weapons to others one by one. To me, this is a terrible condition. We should better get rid of this feeling and hold fast to our weapons.

(2) Freedom from passions:

The second kind of freedom is freedom from passions and evil thoughts—in other words, conquest of passions or attainment of brahmacharya (chastity). This is a full-fledged pursuit, which includes control over all the organs. Control of the palate is particularly important in this context. It is acknowledged by all spiritual seekers that achieving this control is a particularly important part of the quest for attaining freedom from passions, and it is also a test to judge our progress in that direction. However, as life is closely associated with the objects of palate, we often let loose the palate even while trying to control other sense organs. This is a serious error, whereby the roots of passions are watered and the tree of passions blossoms forth even though its branches are cut. Therefore, while impressing upon the readers the need to control the palate, this book tells the following remedies:

(a) The first and the general remedy is to give up spices and condiments altogether as far as possible.

(b) A stronger remedy is to cultivate a feeling that we eat just in order to sustain the body and never for taste. For this purpose, the examples of air and water have been cited: *"We take in air not for taste, but for life. Just as we take water to quench our thirst, in the same way we should take food only to satisfy hunger."*

Jnanadeva has said that a spiritual seeker should consume food not for the indulgence of palate, not to strengthen the body, not to satisfy hunger, but only to sustain life to support the body, it being the vehicle for spiritual pursuit.

Gandhiji has repeatedly condemned indulgence of the palate, but he has also condemned the desire to strengthen the body at one place in this book, which attracts attention:

"As the soul progresses towards freedom from sin, the body also tends to become immune from disease. But a healthy body, in this case, does not mean a strong body. A powerful soul lives only in a weak body. As the soul advances in strength, the body languishes. A perfectly healthy body might yet be quite emaciated. A strong body is often diseased."

This is a distinctive idea. We need not go into its logical examination. Rather, we should test the veracity of the idea through actual experience, trusting the insight of Jnanadeva, the master of wisdom and Gandhiji, the epitome of selfless action. Jnanadeva also condemns the desire to satisfy hunger. We should take this to mean that food should be consumed only because we have decided to do so for the sake of spiritual pursuit, and not out of impulsive submission to any inclination. This scientific attitude as regards consumption of food is the second remedy for control of the palate.

(c) The third remedy is what Gandhiji considers the best one and calls it a golden rule: it is Ramanama.

"One may repeat any mantra one pleases. One must be completely absorbed in whatever mantra one selects. One should not mind if other thoughts disturb one during the japa (recitation). I am confident that one who still goes on with the japa in faith will conquer in the end."

In short, purification of diet, scientific attitude and remembrance of the Lord's Name are the three remedies for attaining freedom from passions. But ultimately Gandhiji sums up all the three in Ramanama alone. He says:

"Orthodox aids to brahmacharya pale into insignificance before Ramanama. The surest remedy for all our ills is Ramanama."

Then he regains his balance and says,

"Eleven vows are, of course, there to attain this unfailing remedy. But many means are such that it becomes difficult to say which is a means and which is an end."

After saying this, he reaffirms his faith:

"Ramanama is the golden means to attain and maintain control of the senses."

After reading this, I was reminded of the Ramaraksha-stotra¹⁸, which I had learnt by heart in childhood. The idea behind it is indeed wonderful.

(3) Freedom from diseases:

Now we turn to the freedom from diseases. This has taken more than half portion of this book. This should not

18. Literally, a hymn seeking protection from Rama. It is a famous hymn written by sage Vishwamitra and sings the praise of Lord Rama, pleading protection from Him. There was a custom in Maharashtra to make children learn it by heart.

create an impression that it is the greatest benefit from Ramanama. This subject has taken so much space because Gandhiji has hit upon this idea while exploring nature cure for the poor, and he has been propagating it in that connection. That is why it has been his constant refrain:

"Perhaps I am right in saying that the potency of Ramanama was brought vividly home to me in Uruli Kanchan."

Whenever he became convinced about a particular thing, he started propagating it. Yet it should be borne in mind that he does not consider freedom from diseases as something apart from the freedom from passions. He considers it an external manifestation of the latter. He has insisted that a person free from passions cannot have any disease. There can be difference of opinion in this respect, and objections have been raised, citing examples of great men. They have been politely replied:

"Laws of nature are applicable to the great men as well."

Gandhiji writes about himself (in 1924):

"My thoughts of sin are scotched, but not killed. If I have acquired perfect mastery over my thoughts, I should not have suffered from pleurisy, dysentery and appendicitis."

And he writes again:

"I hold that appendicitis was a result of infirmity of thought or mind, so do I concede that my submission to the surgical operation was an additional infirmity of mind. If I was absolutely free of egoism, I would have resigned myself to the inevitable."

This is an article written twenty-five years ago. In a letter written a day before his death, he says,

"Both the kidney and the liver got involved this time. According to my view, it showed weakness of faith in Ramanama."

I had heard this faith from him in our very first meeting. I went to him for the first time on 7 June 1916. At that time, ashram was at Kochrab near Ahmedabad. He was cutting vegetables and he initiated me into that work. In the conversation that ensued, he made preliminary enquiries about me and expressed some thoughts. They included the belief that a person free from passions ought to be perfectly healthy. I immediately concurred with him.

Perhaps the reason was that I was a devotee of the Gita, and the Gita had prepared me for such belief. The Gita does not have the ideal of lopsided development that has deviated from its focus. The ideal that the Gita recommends is that of a person who is perfectly developed, is firm on his focus and is worth emulation from all the angles. His every activity—his speaking, sitting, walking, eating, drinking, sleeping—is scientific. It is not so because he has studied the relevant sciences; it is natural to him as he has mastered something, has the vision of something that includes all the knowledge necessary for spiritual life. There is nothing more that he needs to know.

Wherever the Lord's Name is being recited, there is freedom from passions; and where there is freedom from passions, there is perfect health—this is a faith that we must treasure. I call this faith, and not an opinion. There is reasoning behind it, and the Gita has indicated it. Freedom from passions results when one develops *sattva* in him and yet remains detached from it. *Sattva* being extremely pure, knowledge and health are its natural consequences.¹⁹ It is generally believed that a man of *sattva*

19. '*Sattva*, being stainless, is light-giving and healing; it binds with the bonds of attachment and knowledge.'—Gita, 14.6

would possess good character, and that he would be a moral being, but he is not expected to be necessarily intelligent. Similarly, a man of *sattva* is not believed to be invariably healthy. And we do find good, virtuous persons dull-witted or diseased. But this is not what the Gita envisages. We should realize that the Gita is presenting a scientific definition.

When one thinks what should be expected where *rajas* and *tamas* are totally absent and *sattva* is in full bloom, one is invariably drawn to the Gita's inference. When one has to define a point, it has to be devoid of any dimension. That such a point is impossible to find is another matter. Ignorance too is an impurity; disease too is an impurity. How can pure *sattva*, which is by definition stainless, tolerate these impurities?

But, as the Gita has held that the final stage (in spiritual progress) is beyond these three *gunas*, some thinkers, who accept that health must accompany *sattva*, do not consider health inevitable in the stage that transcends the *gunas*, taking support from the Gita's saying that 'one who has transcended the *gunas* is not disturbed when radiance, activity or delusion rise nor when they cease to exist' (14.22). But I would humbly submit that they err in understanding the meaning of this saying.

If it is true that the stage transcending the *gunas* is attained only after the purification of *sattva*, it follows that it should have something more than the pure *sattva*, certainly not less. The additional factor is that the ego of possessing the *sattva* gets eliminated in it; even the sense of possessing *sattva* exists no longer. But I would not like to stretch logic further. I have, therefore, stated at the outset that I would prefer to cherish this faith. I have received a lot of comfort from it, and so it is dear to me.

Perfect health

I would like to add one more thing. In Sanskrit, there is a single word indicating belief in Self and perfect health—*swastha*.²⁰ And the attributes of such a person, given in the Gita are the same as those given in the Charak Samhita.²¹

But this book (Gandhiji's 'Ramanama') indicates something different at two or three places while mentioning the association of physical and spiritual health, which compels us to think deeper:

"I have come to the conclusion, based on observation and scriptural reading, that when a man comes to that living faith in the Unseen power and has become free from passion, the body undergoes internal transformation. This does not come about by mere wish. It needs constant vigilance and practice. In spite of both, unless God's grace descends upon one, human effort comes to naught."

This is the summary of a press report. Gandhiji has tried to clarify the point more in an article written two years later:

"A friend versed in religious lore who read my remarks on Ramanama some time ago wrote to say that Ramanama is an alchemy such as can transform the body. The conservation of the vital energy has been likened to accumulated wealth, but it is in the power of Ramanama alone to make it a running stream of ever-increasing spiritual strength, ultimately making a fall impossible."

20. Literally, one settled in Self, and therefore at ease with oneself.

21. A celebrated text on ayurveda, the Indian science of medicine.

Divine transformation

I do not know who this friend is whom Gandhiji has referred to here. There is no mention or indication in the index either. But this claim of divine transformation of the body is found in the ancient literature on yoga. In the modern times, Sri Aurobindo has advanced such thesis. It is considered his distinctive idea. The claim in yoga literature and the one made by Gandhiji appears similar, but I think that there is a difference. When Gandhiji was asked about yogic practices, he replied,

"I am a stranger to yogic practices. The practice I follow is a practice (Ramanama) I learnt in my childhood. What I learnt in my childhood has become a huge thing in my mental firmament. It is a sun that has brightened my darkest hour."

This clarification does not take us far. But it does indicate that there is difference between yoga literature and Gandhiji's thought. I think the difference is this: the divine transformation in the body that yoga literature talks about is a kind of *siddhi*²² and the transformation that Gandhiji envisages is a natural result of perfect purity and consequent appearance of divine consciousness. Jnanadeva has described this transformation in an incomparable bhajan (devotional song):

"Intelligence and understanding were separate in many births (for a very long time); now the separation has come to an end. The two have now become one, and consequently even the limbs have gained life. The whole body has undergone divine transformation—it has as if been filled with nectar."

This is what 'freedom from diseases' through Ramanama means. And it also means freedom from passions.

22. Supernatural power.

Ramanama as a treatment

We have seen up till now what I find to be the philosophical discussion about the attainment of three kinds of freedom through Ramanama. In fact, the three kinds are ultimately one and the same. Their separate treatment has been considered useful only because their practical applications are different. Out of these, practical application of freedom from diseases has been explained in this book in some detail. We would now turn to that part.

Mellowed position

When we come to practice from theory, Gandhiji's position gets somewhat mellowed. He writes:

"A true devotee of God faithfully obeys the five elemental forces of nature. If he so obeys, he will not fall ill. If perchance he does, he will cure himself with the aid of the elements. It is not for the dweller in the body to get the body cured anyhow. He who realizes that the soul is something apart from the body, will not be perturbed nor mourn if the elements fail. On the contrary, he will welcome death as a friend. He will become his own healer instead of seeking for medical men."

There are three thoughts, coming one after another:

1. A devotee never contracts any disease.
2. If he does, he cures himself through change in diet etc.
3. If he cannot get so cured, he leaves the body peacefully.

No further elaboration is necessary. It is clear that while practically applying the thought, the absolute commitment has been somewhat diluted.

A talk at Uruli Kanchan makes it clearer:

"For some of the ailments, there is no earthly cure. For

instance, Ramanama cannot perform the miracle of restoring to you a lost limb. But it can perform the still greater miracle of helping you to enjoy an ineffable peace in spite of the loss while you live, and rob death of its sting and the grave its victory at the journey's end."

The miracle of remaining peaceful despite illness is no less than the miracle of remaining free from diseases through Ramanama. It can even be said that it highlights the glory of Ramanama in a different, significant way. Here Ramanama is supposed to have limited power of producing miracles; Tulsidas would not have agreed to it. But this is the reason why this book can satisfy even rational minds.

Ramanama and nature cure

In short, it is not the power of imagination suffused with emotions that is at play here while recommending Ramanama as a treatment; practical considerations while applying the idea in practice have been paid full attention. Although nature cure has been combined with Ramanama, I would prefer to call Gandhiji's ideas as 'Ramanama cure' instead of nature cure. Gandhiji's own words make this clear. He writes at one place:

"(Nature cure) is not complementary to Ramanama. It is but a means of its realization. Ramanama does not in fact require any aid. But to claim belief in Ramanama and at the same time to run to doctors do not go hand in hand."

At another place, he writes in a letter:

"Nature cure treatment brings us nearer to God. I will have no objection whatever if we could do even without it."

And at a third place:

"I have known parents who have trifled with their children's diseases even to the extent of trusting them to their (the parents') recitation of Ramanama."

This cites an extreme example. What it means is that Ramanama as a cure is free from most of the unnecessary and costly paraphernalia which is associated with nature cure these days.

Three points in cure

I would put in three points what Gandhiji has elaborated as regards this cure:

1. One should not have much attachment to the body. Such attachment may keep the body well-nourished, but it causes decay of the soul. Often that harms the body as well.

2. We should identify with the poor. At least as far as illness is concerned, we should not hope for the treatment which millions of the poor cannot afford.

3. We should look upon the surrounding nature as a friend and not an enemy. we should not be afraid of the nature. Aid of light, air, sunlight etc. should be taken fully and liberally.

If we keep these points in mind, we would be able to grasp the entire discussion in this book.

Scattered suggestions

Now, some scattered suggestions:

"There is no place in it (my nature cure) for the microscope, X-rays and similar things. Nor is there room in nature cure for medicines such as quinine and penicillin."

"It should not always be necessary to consult a nature cure practitioner."

"To learn nature cure, it is not necessary to learn anatomy."

"Sweet lime is not a part of nature cure."

If the three points are grasped from the heart, all these ideas can be well assimilated. They should not be

taken only literally; their spirit should also be grasped. It has been rightly said, "The letter kills, but the Spirit gives life."

Summing up

To sum up, it is transformation in life that is called for:

- (a) Pure, clean, proper and limited diet on a regular basis and eating sparingly or fasting whenever necessary.
- (b) Purification of body, speech and mind and cleanliness of surroundings.
- (c) Love of nature and taking full advantage of it.
- (d) A plan for proper labour and rest.
- (e) To realize our separateness from the body, to dedicate ourselves to the service of all the creatures and have unbroken remembrance of God with a pure heart.

This is how one should live. This is what is called brahmacharya. And this is what Ramanama as a cure is all about.

Three concerns

This book reflects on every page the conviction with which the Vaishnava devotees have sung the glory of Ramanama. Yet there is a major difference. Let us discuss it here in brief. The difference is that the devotees sung the glory of the Name with gay abandon, while there are three concerns behind Gandhiji's propagation of Ramanama. Let us have a look at them one by one.

Attachment to desires

The first concern is that Ramanama should have nothing to do with attachment to desires. He writes:

"No one should ever use such sacred mantra for material gains. We frequently find its recitation taking place for show or selfish gains."

The devotees have gone to the extent of saying that even though the recitation of Name is for personal gains, it does lead to some good. There are two languages: one presents the principle in a rational way, with concern for analysis; and the another presents it in a sentimental fashion, taking for granted some intelligence in the listeners. I appreciate both the languages. The Gita has used both the languages. Yet she puts particular emphasis on detachment.

Here I will turn to the Gita for a while. If it appears digression, readers will pardon me, taking into account my devotion for the Gita.

In the seventh chapter of the Gita, three kinds of devotees have been mentioned: (i) those restless for God's grace (*aarta*), (ii) seekers of knowledge (*jijnasu*) and (iii) seekers of well-being (*artharthi*). Many commentators consider all of them as the devotees desirous of worldly gains. I do not concur with this, as the Gita has called all of them '*udaar*' (noble), a term opposite to '*kripan*' (pitiable) and has made it clear that such pitiable people are desirous of the fruit of action: '*कृपणाः फलहेतवः*' (2.49). It means that all the three kinds of devotees are desireless. But their devotion has not fully blossomed like that of a wise, Self-realized person. *Aarta* does not mean one who is afflicted with a disease and wants to get rid of it; *aarta* means an emotional devotee. *Jijnasu* does not mean one with normal curiosity; he is one who wants to understand the Supreme through reason. *Artharthi* does not mean one who seeks material gains for himself; he is one who seeks and works for the well-being of all. I would not further discuss this point here. I have discussed this in detail in 'Talks on the Gita' and those interested in the matter can refer to it. In my view, all those whom the Gita acknowledges as devotees are fully desireless.

The Gita has put the devotees who seek worldly

gains in a different category; and although they have not been acknowledged as true devotees,—she does find fault with them—she does have sympathy for them. They have been described in the same chapter as those ‘who are full of longings and therefore seek refuge in other gods’ (7.20).

Those who are full of longings are necessarily devotees of other gods, although they may be taking the Name of God. I was having discussion with a gentleman. He said, “It is a great contribution by Islam that it rejected various gods by fortifying faith in one God.” I said, “I too agree with it. But do not think that all those who take the Name of Allah are necessarily devotees of one God. If one is seeking wealth from Allah, he is, in fact, a devotee of goddess Laxmi. He is no different from a Hindu who prays for the grace of Laxmi. On the other hand, a person may be taking the Name of Laxmi, but if he is seeking purification of mind or peace of mind, he is a devotee of one God.” The Gita has explained this idea in the saying, कांक्षन्तः कर्मणां सिद्धिं यजन्त इह देवताः—those who desire fruit of actions are worshippers of other gods (4.12).

It would vitiate Ramanama if we recite it and continue to harbour desires even if they are fulfilled. It would make it a name of another god. And at times it may even become the name of devil! This concern is found in page after page in this book, and this is perfectly right.

But I would not take this to mean that one who takes the treatment of allopathic doctors, following the convention, is not entitled to take Ramanama; and certainly Gandhiji too cannot have such a stand.

Different interpretations

I am reminded of an incident in my childhood. I was quite a sickly child and used to have medicines from

doctors. My mother would ask me to chant while taking the medicine, औषधं जाह्नवीतोयं वैद्यो नारायणो हरिः.²³ I would do accordingly. But one day I thought of a different interpretation and said, “I think it means that the Ganga’s water should be considered a medicine and God should be looked upon as a doctor.” Mother said, “This is all right. But to interpret it in this way needs particular worthiness. For me and you, a different interpretation is right.” “What is that?”, I enquired. Mother said, “Doctor should be looked upon as God and medicine should be looked upon as the water of Ganga.” I would accept what she said from her standpoint.

But an ayurvedic practitioner told me yet another meaning of this saying the other day. He said, “This saying refers to what should be done when the disease is incurable.” I accepted this interpretation also, as we do find people continuing to force medicine down the throat of the patient till the patient breathes his last. It is indeed kindness on their part that they do not continue to give medicines after death! Perhaps this would become a reality one day, as the science of medicine is in the process of trying to revive dead persons.

A nature cure practitioner told me, “This saying is not propagating meek surrender to one’s destiny; it is rather suggesting nature cure. It means that one should not take medicines; one should instead prefer water therapy and consider Narayan Hari, that is the Sun-god, to be a doctor—in other words, take benefit of his rays scientifically.” I accepted this too. But I gathered from all this is that Ramanama is different from nature cure.

23. The saying can be interpreted in two ways, which have been subsequently explained in child Vinayak’s conversation with his mother.

One may ask at this point, "You link Ramanama with nature cure and also delink it from nature cure. You condemn association of desires with Ramanama as a vitiating factor and also expect health from it. What does this mean?" The reply is: One expects Ramanama to be health-giving because the Self is, by nature, untouched by illness. So, expectation to remain healthy, in effect, means expectation to stay settled in one's Self. It should not, therefore, be counted as a desire. The Self is devoid of diseases, and it is also separate from the body. So, if the body falls off while one is reciting Ramanama, so be it. Such peaceful dissociation with the body is not failure but success of Ramanama as a cure. We link Ramanama with nature cure because nature cure is concerned with the right conduct of life, which includes right diet etc. If Ramanama is not linked with such conduct of life, should it be linked to wrong conduct? And Ramanama is delinked from nature cure, because the latter's ostentatious paraphernalia, often costlier than modern medicines, reduces it to a sham.

Spread of superstition

This is one concern. The second one is that the propagation of Ramanama should not encourage superstition. When Gandhiji presented Ramanama as a cure, he was bombarded with questions. One asked, "We do *poojas* to goddess Mariamma and it is almost miraculous to see most of the cases (of smallpox) come out successful. For stomach pain, even chronic cases, many make vows before the deity of Tirupathi; and finding themselves cured, fulfil their ablutions and other obligations. Is what you say is akin to this?"

Gandhiji's answer is:

"The examples that have been quoted are neither of nature cure nor yet Ramanama. But they do show how nature cures without any treatment in many cases."

On reading this, I was reminded of a story from Socrates' life. It was claimed at that time that praying to an idol in a temple cured patients; names of such patients had been written in that temple. When Socrates was asked about his opinion about that phenomenon, he quipped, "Names of those who did not get cured should also be displayed there, so that people could make a comparative assessment of that claim!"

Gandhiji adds:

"Ramanama is the enemy of superstition. Faith cure, if I know it correctly, is blind cure such as the friend describes, and thereby ridicules the living name of the living God. The latter is not a figment of one's imagination. It is conscious belief in God and a knowledge of His law that makes perfect cure possible without any further aid. It is claimed that realization of God in the heart makes it impossible for an impure or idle thought to cross the mind. Disease is impossible where there is purity of thought."

It is abundantly clear that Gandhiji's Ramanama is not the least incongruous with pure rationalism.

At another place, Gandhiji has made it still clearer:

"Ramanama is not like black magic. Rather, it is a mathematical formula, which sums up in brief the result of endless research."

Being a lover of mathematics, I am happy with this sentence. Yoga and mathematics are but two sides of the same thing; in fact, they are two terms for the same thing. James Jeans, a mathematician, has written a beautiful book titled 'Mysterious universe', wherein he has described the mathematical faculty of the Lord. This is not something new for us. We have given the term '*samkhya*' to the science of nature. Self-knowledge is also known by the term '*samkhya*', because it takes into account and examines every activity of the mind. Samkhya and yoga are two

kinds of mathematics. Samkhya is pure mathematics, while yoga is applied mathematics.

However, it is painful to find all the sects of devotees full of superstitions. When I was studying the Quran, I used to read with particular interest prefaces of different editions to gain insights into the Quran. But I found many prefaces suggesting faith cure only: If your stomach is aching, write down a particular *ayat* on paper, burn that paper, mix its ash with water and drink that water—this is the kind of cure that has been suggested! For headache, same thing is to be done with another *ayat*. Many other religious books like the Saptashati, Gurucharitra, Tulsi-Ramayana or Granthasahib are no different. So many absurd things that have absolutely nothing to do with the purification of mind are routinely done. For me, these are indications of the lack of belief in God. As far as I know, it was Shankaracharya who made the best effort to save Hindu dharma from the lack of belief in God which superstitions indicate. This was the reason of his vehement opposition to mechanical rites and rituals. He wanted to remove blind faith. But it has persisted despite his great efforts.

This is exactly what Gandhiji has done in this book. In this book, more than half of his strength has been spent in fighting superstition and showing how Ramanama and superstition are poles apart. He passionately opposes popularisation of superstition by turning the Lord's Name into some kind of charm. At one place, he has gone to the extent of saying that it has made him apprehensive about the propagation of Ramanama.

Limitations of Ramanama

Then he begins to note the limitations of Ramanama:

"The remedy for surfeit is fasting, not prayer. Prayer can come in only when fasting has done its work. It can make fasting easy and bearable."

"It is the duty of the man who takes the Name of God with heart to understand and follow the laws of nature, which God has prescribed for man."

"If one has no control over one's thoughts, if one does not mind, for instance, sleeping in a hole of a room with all doors and windows shut, and breathing foul air or drinking dirty water, his recitation of Ramanama is in vain."

Christian Science

In the West, belief in what is called Christian Science is prevalent. It believes that all diseases and even death are the consequences of sins; hence a perfectly pure and passionless person need not even die physically. Gandhiji opines in this connection,

"Ramanama has the flavour of faith-healing and Christian Science, yet it is quite distinct from them. I have no quarrel with Christian Science. I accept the doctrine in toto; but what I do not understand about Christian scientists is that they make altogether too much of physical health and disease."

Here Gandhiji is alluding to the belief that a perfectly passionless person would not die.

But this should have been expressed in clearer words. This has not happened. On the contrary, support of Christian Science appears to have been taken at a place while fortifying the glory of Ramanama:

"Christian Science says similar, if not exactly the same thing (as Ramanama)."

I find this part in the book confusing. To accept Christian science in toto, and yet say that one does not understand the point it emphasises most; to say that Ramanama is quite distinct from it and yet say that they are broadly similar—this does not clarify the matter. I know that this is because of the idea that a good part in any thing should not be rejected. Yet I feel that more

clarity was called for. Let me state my opinion in this regard: That a perfectly passionless person should not die, is the limit of blind faith. Philosophy would say that a perfectly passionless person would find it impossible to stay within the body. Even if he is forced to stay within the body because of *prarabdha*²⁴, or in other words, because of existence of some practically dead residue of passions, it is certain that he would not have to take another birth. Attachment to the physical body is contrary to devotion and therefore, in my opinion, the idea of physical immortality is inconsistent with faith in God. If Christian Science continues to stick to this idea, it would neither be Christian nor science. Desire for physical immortality gave birth to alchemy—and it is said, to chemistry as well. Perhaps the yogic practices here have arisen out of this very desire. But it can never lead to Self-knowledge.

God and the Self

Finding the devotion all over the world filled with blind faith, social scientists have come to the conclusion that the idea of God must have germinated in the primitive man's mind, which was full of fear and ignorant of science. They believe that the idea of God represents darkness which would be gradually dispelled with the spread of the light of science. But if God is darkness, it is bound to be dispelled one day; and that would be a healthy development. God of those who believe that He is distinct from the Self, is creator of the world and is sitting in some remote heaven somewhere outside the world, is indeed in trouble! But Vedanta (Upanishadic philosophy)

24. According to Hindu philosophy, one is required to go through the cycle of births and deaths to reap the fruits of one's actions. *Prarabdha karma* is that part of the accumulated actions which is responsible for the present birth and which one has to exhaust in this birth through enjoyment or suffering.

has not taught us such concept of God. It teaches that God is nothing but the Self with extreme and perfect purity, and devotion to Him is nothing but the height of efforts on our part. This is what Gandhiji intends to convey when he recommends faith in Ramanama. Therefore, although fed up with the stupid and hypocrites, he has said that he is afraid of propagating Ramanama, he has continued to propagate it. He says, *"Though people may misuse something, we cannot hide a truth."*

Devotion to the Lord is not something different from efforts for elevating the Self or purifying the heart; in fact, it is complementary to them. Gandhiji has expressed this in these words:

"It can be said with justice that possession of a pure heart should do equally well without Ramanama. Only, I know no other way of attaining purity."

Purification of heart through one's own efforts is the primary spiritual pursuit. When we couple it with devotion, it only means that we put before us for contemplation an ideal of utmost purity. It makes the pursuit constructive and easier. Otherwise, during the efforts for self-purification evil is constantly thought about, even though with a view to eliminate it, and it makes the spiritual pursuit negative in character and more difficult. Besides, it is an actual experience that just as effort of breathing by the lungs gets aid from air in the atmosphere, efforts of the Self, caged within the body, receive aid from God, who has pervaded the whole universe.

In short, Ramanama is a process of self-purification; not of flattering imaginary deities or some God who is apart from the Self, through superstitious beliefs.

Mechanical recitation

The third concern in this book is that Ramanama should not remain just a mindless routine practice. It is

not just a word, but also an extremely subtle and perfect idea. But recitation of Ramanama is normally associated with mere recitation of the letters 'Ra-ma'. It is believed that if one has these words on one's lips at the time of death, one would be redeemed. A devotee once told me, "The word 'Ra-ma' is opposite of 'ma-ra' which refers to death; so Ramanama is that which is the opposite of death." Ramanama, for this devotee, is just a particular word—not even a word, as words have meaning, but just a meaningless collection of letters! If a person thinks in such a way to fortify his faith, I would not contradict him. But such artificially contrived ideas cannot uplift a human being much.

Some protagonists of devotion or traditional rites and rituals have gone to the extent of insisting that the words taken for recitation should not have any meaning at all. It has been a contention that reflection on meaning weakens the power in the chanting of Vedic mantras. It is argued that the power of a mantra lies in the utterance of particular letters. When we are actually eating a bread, what is the point in reflecting over the statement 'we are eating a bread'? Utterance of the Lord's Name or recitation of a Vedic mantra is as fruitful as eating. Not even this, it is also contended that just as reflection during eating may impede the process of digestion, reflection while uttering the Lord's Name would be an obstacle preventing us from getting benefited from the Name. And if one is to reflect, what is the use of taking Ramanama? One can reflect as one pleases without taking any Name. When you are taking the Name of the Lord, there is no question of reflection, as the Name itself is redeeming. In this way, a theory has been constructed in support of mere utterance of the Lord's Name. Here I have presented that doctrine as constructively and sympathetically as possible.

Gandhiji, on the contrary, has stressed reflection, understanding and practice. A single quotation will suffice as an example:

"Mere mechanical repetition of Ramanama cannot give strength. For that, one has to understand and live up to the conditions attached to its recitation. To take God's Name, one has to live a godly life."

Reflection on attributes

Bhishmadeva, the expounder of Vishnusahasranam, has the same expectation when he instructs Yudhishtira. He has termed the thousand Names as 'gauna', that is, expressing different attributes. Every Name of the Lord stands for one or the other attribute. It means that while taking that Name, a seeker should reflect over that particular attribute. Actual practice has also been equally emphasised:

सर्वांगमानाम् आचारः प्रथमं परिकल्पते ।

आचार-प्रभवो धर्मः धर्मस्य प्रभुरच्युतः ॥

—"Practice is the foundation of all scriptures. *Dharma*²⁵ arises out of practice, and the Lord is the master of dharma." What it conveys is that remembrance of the Lord's Name provides motivation for right conduct. Hence remembrance of the Lord is the highest dharma. This naturally calls for constant vigilance on the part of human beings. Bhishma has categorically told this at the very outset of the Vishnusahasranam: स्तुवन् नाम-सहस्रेण पुरुषः सततोत्थितः—'a man uttering the Lord's Name should be ever-vigilant'.

25. 'Dharma' is normally translated as 'religion', but the concept is much wider in scope than 'religion'. Dharma is that which holds and supports everything in the world. Its meaning includes right conduct and duties.

Merit in the recitation

But even after accepting the importance of reflection and practice the doctrine of mere utterance would not be refuted so long the essential truth in it is not accepted. And the essential truth in it is that speech is situated in between the inner and the outer world, and so is a conduit for communication between these two worlds. Hence guarding the speech and keeping it pure facilitates purification of life. Utterance too has thus its own value like practice and reflection. Tulsidas has explained this beautifully:

रामनाम मनि-दीप धरु , जीह देहीं द्वार
तुलसी भीतर बाहेरहुं जौं चाहसि उजिआर ।

(Tulsidas says, if you want light, both inwards and outwards, you should keep the lamp of Ramanama in the mouth, the doorstep between the two.)

So, one has to accept that utterance of the Name has its own independent value. Gandhiji has accepted it with open mind. Let us see his answer to a question:

Q.: Is it not enough to have Ramanama in one's heart, or is there something special in its recitation?

A.: "I believe there is special merit in the recitation of Ramanama. If anyone knows that God is in truth residing in his heart, I admit that for him there is no need for recitation. But I have not known such a person. On the contrary, my personal experience tells me that there is something quite extraordinary in the recitation of Ramanama. Why or how is not necessary to know."

One statement is even clearer:

"If recitation of Ramanama continues unabated, it would one day descend to your heart from the mouth."

Tukaram has said the same thing: नसे तरी मनीं नसो, परी वाचे तरी वसो—'Even if Ramanama is not there in your mind,

let it at least be in the mouth.'

When the value of recitation is thus accepted, it does not go against the significance of reflection, meditation and practice. In fact, it brings it into sharp relief. And this is Gandhiji's precise purpose in discussing the pros and cons of mere recitation.

In short, there are three pitfalls in the path of devotion: attachment to desires, superstitious beliefs and mere mechanical repetition. These must be avoided. These three scatter thorns in the path of devotion, which is otherwise easy to tread upon. Hence, this book persistently underlines the need to be vigilant while singing the glory of Ramanama. The train of Ramanama needs the track made of knowledge and action. It cannot roam freely like an airplane.

Fruition of Ramanama

But at one place, the flight is so high that it cannot be even called the flight of an airplane. It should better be likened to the spacecraft. Scientists harbour the desire to cross the gravitational pull of the earth to land on the Mars. In this book, the flight of thinking is so high at a place that Ramanama itself becomes redundant. Gandhiji writes:

"I do look forward to a time when even repeating the Name of Rama will become a hindrance. When I have realized that Rama transcends even speech, I shall have no need to repeat the Name."

The same thought has been suggested in the Vishnusahasranam in two words. Vishnusahasranam is not a treatise of philosophical discussion; it just lists the Names of the Lord one after another. There are two Names in it: शब्दातिगः शब्दसहः—the Lord is beyond words and He puts up with His description in words. What need does He have for our words? And can He ever be adequately described in words? We seek to praise Him,

but our effort, in effect, proves to be disparagement. Is it not better then to keep silent?

Gandhiji answers:

"May be. But there is no point in artificial silence. Living silence needs great efforts."

Recitation and action

This needs to be properly understood. Normally we take it to mean that we should go on doing good deeds. Protagonists of action always assert that if we put our thoughts in practice, there is no need to talk about them. Gandhiji too has said this many a time. But here he means something different. Before having a look at it, let us see what the supporters of action contend.

They say: prayer, worship etc. are unnecessary; it is sufficient if we are engaged throughout the day in good deeds. If we cannot do so, we may make it up by prayer etc. One may do so by all means, but one should not entertain high expectations from such things. Often, that would be a waste of time or a kind of deception. Mind would deceive itself and an attitude to tolerate lapses in practice would develop. Perhaps one would become increasingly inactive. It is, therefore, better to remain always active. Action itself would reveal how actions should be purified. It is better to have undivided commitment to action alone rather than having it partially to action and partially to prayer. Duality is always troublesome. So you should better decide in favour of action: कर्मभिर् निःश्रेयसम्—action alone leads to deliverance.

We have seen the stand of the supporters of recitation earlier. This emphasis on activism is similar. Bigotry is a characteristic feature of all such extreme stands.

When Gandhiji talks about going beyond the Ramanama, he is not being a protagonist of action. The flight of his thought is, in fact, so high that protagonists

of action would find it unbearable even to conceive it. Let us see what Gandhiji means in his own words:

"A single right thought can envelop the world. It is never wasted. The very attempt to clothe thought in word or action limits it. Who in this world has ever been able to express a thought in word or action fully?"

He adds:

"You can ask whether that means that one should go into perpetual silence. In theory, it is possible. But it is very difficult to fulfil the conditions by which silent thought could be made effective. I for one cannot claim to have attained the requisite intensity or control over thought. Although I have not fully realized it in practice, I have envisaged it in the mind."

Thus, Gandhiji has rejected both word and action here. We often say, and Gandhiji too has said often, that thoughts should be put into practice; a thought sans action is powerless. But here he says something that is absolutely contrary to it: *"The very attempt to clothe thought in word or action limits it."*

We have reached here the threshold of *sannyasa* (renunciation of worldly life).

Action and renunciation

I know that the word '*sannyasa*' would make some people angry with me. But I cannot help if Gandhiji, known for his action-orientedness, envisages the picture of renunciation in his mind. It was the same case with Shankaracharya. Throughout his life, he continued to act, while he kept on talking about renunciation.

The word '*sannyasa*' evokes in the mind the impression of powerless inactivity. But there is a power beyond action, which cannot be surpassed by the most intense actions. This is the power of renunciation, which is full of knowledge. Nonviolence can be that of the brave

and that of the weak. Nonviolence of the brave is hundred times more powerful than violence. Same is the case with renunciation. In the ultimate state of *sannyasa* any action, even a good or mild one, is a kind of violence. This stage may be unreachable while one is encased in the body, but one must aspire for it. Human birth is for that very purpose. Human figure gives the same indication: legs may be on the ground, but the head should be high up in the sky. Action facilitates thinking up to a point. But thereafter it becomes a hindrance. The Gita has explained this beautifully. Action in inaction and inaction in action—that is what the Gita teaches. The wise who have vision of the Self do not work even while appearing to be involved in activity, and work even while appearing to be inactive. One who experiences this has gained all the knowledge that could be gained, attained the highest yoga, achieved all that could be achieved: स बुद्धिमान् मनुष्येषु स युक्तः कृत्स्न-कर्म-कृत्.²⁶

To an objection by a protagonist of action to Shankaracharya's exposition of *sannyasa*, that renunciation involves abandonment of duties, Shankaracharya accepts it, and replies: अलङ्कारो हि अयं अस्माकं यत् ब्रह्मात्मावगतौ सत्यां सर्वकर्तव्यता-हानिः कृतकृत्यता चेति—"We consider it an ornament, an adornment, that the vision of the Self results in the loss of all obligations and a human being fulfils all the objects and purpose of life."²⁷

This is what the Ramanama leads to; and this is what it achieves.



26. He is enlightened among men, he is a yogi, he has done all that he needs do.—Gita, 4.18

27. Shankaracharya's commentary on the Brahmasutra, 1.1.4